

PUBLIC NOTICE
BEFORE THE HON'BLE STATE
CONSUMER DISPUTE REDRESSAL
COMMISSION CHENNAI
C.M.P.No. 980 OF 2025
IN
F.A.No. 1054 OF 2025
AGAINST
C.C.No. 225 OF 2024

(On the file of the District Consumer
Disputes Redressal Commission,
Chennai North)

Mrs. Jayanthi G, W/o.
R.Guruvayya,
And another ...Petitioners/Appellants

Vs

1. JAISHRI MOTORS
Rep. by its Authorised signatory
No.2A, Ethiraj Salai, Erukkuancherry,
Tamilnadu, Chennai - 600 118.

2. KLB KOMAKI PVT. LTD.
Rep. by its Authorised signatory
Building No.10, First Floor, Rani Jhansi
Road, Jhandewalan, New Delhi-
110055.

3. KLB KOMAKI PVT. LTD.
Rep. by its Authorised signatory
Khasra 37/19/20/22, Kapashera, CNG
Wall Gali, New Delhi-110037.

...Respondents/Complainant

The Petitioner/Appellants above named
filed the above petition against Jaishri
Motors and 3 others in C.M.P.No. 980 of
2025, in F.A.No. 1054 of 2024 against
C.C.No. 225 of 2024, which came up for
hearing on 11/02/2026, before the
Extended to 13/04/2026, came up at the
Hon'ble State Consumer Dispute
Redressal Commission Court. Since, the
PRIVATE Notice sent to **KLB KOMAKI**
PVT. LTD. (2nd Respondent and on the
earlier occasion could not be served the
Hon'ble State Consumer Dispute
Redressal Commission Court was
pleased to order Substitute Service
(Paper Publication) and adjourned the
case to 13.05.2026 at 10:30 a.m.

Kindly enter your appearance in the
above case either in person or through
counsel within the above said period,
failing which the case would be decided
on merits in your absence.

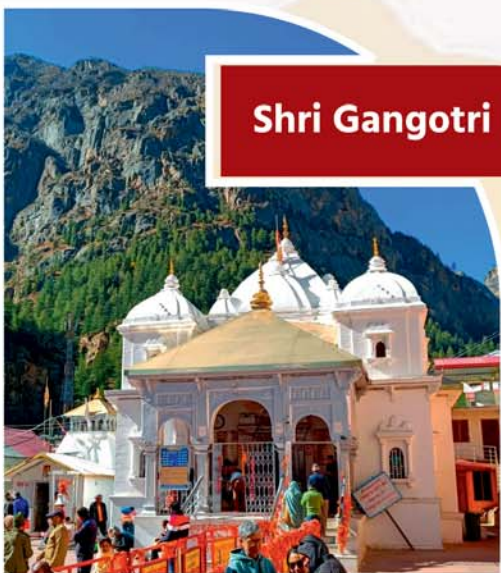
M. Karthik
M. Shruthi Sarojini
Advocate
No. 21, New Addl. Law Chamber,
High Court Buildings, Chennai- 600 104



Shri Yamunotri



Shri Gangotri



Shri Kedarnath



Shri Badrinath



SPIRITUAL AND NATURAL ATTRACTIONS NEAR THE CHAR DHAM ROUTE

Near Yamunotri

Janki Chatti & Hanuman Chatti, Kharsali Village, Saptarishi Kund, Lakhamandal, Kedarkantha Trek, Rana Chatti.

Near Kedarnath

Bhairavnath Temple, Vasuki Tal, Gaurikund, Triyuginarayan Temple, Chopta - Tungnath - Chandra Shila, Deoria Tal.

Near Gangotri

Gaumukh Trek, Bhojbasa & Tapovan, Surya Kund & Gauri Kund, Harsil Valley, Mukhimath (Mukhba), Dayara Bugyal Trek, Gartang Gali, Kashi Vishwanath Temple (Uttarkashi), Nachiketa Tal & Dodital.

Near Badrinath

Mana Village, Vyas Gufa & Ganesh Gufa, Bhimsila, Auli, Valley of Flowers, Vasudhara Falls, Charanpaduka, Tapt Kund & Narad Kund, Jyotirmath (Joshimath), Satopanth Lake, Pandukeshwar, Adibadri Temple, Hemkund Sahib.



Tiryuginarayan Temple



Valley of Flowers



Auli



Devprayag



Gartang Gali



Rishikesh



Harsil Valley



Kartik Swami Temple

Important Information

Mandatory Registration: Registration is compulsory before commencing the Yatra.

Verify Contact Details: Please ensure you enter the correct mobile number during registration.

Be Prepared for Weather: Carry adequate woolen clothes, an umbrella, and a raincoat.

Accurate Health Data: Provide precise health information during the registration process.

Senior Citizen Advisory: Senior citizens are advised to undergo a medical check-up before starting the journey.

Medication: If you are on prescribed medication, carry a sufficient stock of your medicines.

Acclimatisation: Take frequent breaks at various transit points along the route to acclimatize to the high-altitude climate.

Health First: If you feel unwell, please do not proceed with the journey.

Beware of Scams: Avoid unauthorised individuals claiming to facilitate 'Darshan' at the shrines.

Keep Tracks Clean: Cooperate with us in keeping the pilgrimage routes clean; do not litter.

Safe Driving: Maintain controlled vehicle speed and park only in designated parking areas.

No Plastic: Strictly avoid the use of single-use plastic.



“The Honourable Prime Minister has termed the third decade of the 21st century as the 'Decade of Uttarakhand.' In line with the Prime Minister's vision, we are working with an 'unwavering commitment' (Vikalp Rahit Sankalp) to make the state an ideal state in every field.”

Pushkar Singh Dhami
Chief Minister, Uttarakhand

Modes of Registration

Visit the website or scan the QR Code: registrationandtouristcare.uk.gov.in



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Devbhoomi
Uttarakhand
VIKAS BHI, VIRASAT BHI

Chardham Yatra

A WARM WELCOME TO ALL DEVOTEES



My dear Countrymen,

The sacred Chardham Yatra has commenced in the holy land of Devbhoomi Uttarakhand. This divine pilgrimage to the four shrines, including the darshan of Baba Kedar, is a magnificent celebration of India's eternal (Sanatan) cultural consciousness. Jagadguru Adi Shankaracharya gave a new direction to Indian culture through his pilgrimages to Badrinath and Kedarnath. Similarly, Jagadguru Ramanujacharya and Jagadguru Madhvacharya also visited Badrinath to enrich their spiritual philosophies.

Even today, these four shrines nestled in the lap of the Himalayas remain divine centers of our eternal faith and belief. Every year, people belonging to diverse languages, traditions, and cultures come here, further strengthening the spirit of 'Ek Bharat, Shreshtha Bharat'. This year's Yatra is an extension of that very tradition.

Our scriptures state:

अग्निहोमादिभिर्यज्ञैरिष्टा विपुलदक्षिणैः।
न तत्फलमवाप्नोति तीर्थभिर्गमनेन यत्॥

Meaning: The immense merit (Punya) earn through grand Yagyas (sacrificial rituals) and charity is profound. However, the merit obtained through a pilgrimage (Tirtha Yatra) is even greater than that gained through those rituals.

In the resolve for a 'Viksit Bharat' (Developed India), the role of a 'Viksit Uttarakhand' is extremely vital. A few years ago, at the gateway of Baba Kedar, I had said that this decade would be the 'Decade of Uttarakhand.' Today, the progress of Uttarakhand is turning that belief into reality. Uttarakhand is setting new benchmarks in all three sectors: tourism, spirituality, and economic growth.

The great ritual of development (Vikas ka Mahayagya) that has been underway in Uttarakhand for the past few years has made the Chardham Yatra more accessible, safer, and divine than ever before. This is providing great convenience to the visiting devotees, saints, and tourists. In all these efforts, every care is being taken to preserve the natural beauty of Uttarakhand.

I would also urge every guest visiting Uttarakhand to truly enjoy this new experience. During your journey, I encourage all travellers to observe a "Digital Fast" and strive to live within the natural beauty of Uttarakhand. This will provide you with a unique sense of satisfaction.

Historically, we have always traveled from our homes to Devbhoomi for the Chardham Yatra with a specific resolve. In this spirit, I wish to urge you to take Five Resolves (Panch Sankalp):

First Resolve – Cleanliness is Paramount: Maintain cleanliness within and around the shrines. Contribute your part to keeping the rivers clean. Take a pledge for a journey free of single-use plastic and uphold the dignity of this sacred land.

Second Resolve – Sensitivity towards Nature and Environment: Be sensitive toward this divine Himalayan land. While maintaining the balance of nature, contribute to environmental conservation through initiatives like 'Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam' (A Tree in Mother's Name).

Third Resolve – Emphasis on Service, Cooperation, and Unity: Since ancient times, our pilgrimages have been a medium for universal service and social harmony. Even today, people serve pilgrims with this same spirit. I urge every pilgrim visiting the Chardham to perform at least one act of service every day of their journey. Help your fellow travellers and connect with people coming from different parts of the country. By participating in their traditions, strengthen the spirit of 'Ek Bharat, Shreshtha Bharat' through this pilgrimage.

Fourth Resolve – Promoting 'Vocal for Local': From the time you leave your home until you return, ensure that you spend at least five percent of your total travel budget on purchasing local products. Even if a local item is not immediately needed in this season, try to buy it for future use.

Fifth Resolve – Adherence to Discipline, Safety, and Decorum: Follow the rules of the journey and traffic instructions. As a responsible and alert citizen, make this pilgrimage safe and accessible. Let us ensure that our journey does not cause any inconvenience to the people involved in the organisation and management of this Yatra.

In recent years, a large number of creators and influencers have started visiting the Chardham. I urge all of you to make an effort to share the local stories of Uttarakhand and its small, unique traditions with the masses.

May the blessings of Baba Kedar and all the four shrines infuse your life with new energy, new inspiration, and new resolutions. This is my wish for you.

My heartiest best wishes to all of you for a successful, safe, divine, and soulful journey.

Yours

Narendra Modi



Panch Kedar

1. Kedarnath
2. Tungnath
3. Rudranath
4. Madhmaheshwar
5. Kalpeswar



Panch Prayag

1. Devprayag
2. Rudraprayag
3. Karnprayag
4. Nandprayag
5. Vishnuprayag



Panch Badri

1. Vishal Badri
2. Yogdarshan Badri
3. Bhavya Badri
4. Vradha Badri
5. Aadi Badri



Use only the official portal for Helicopter Bookings To Avoid any Fraud
www.heliyatra.ircctc.co.in



During the Chardham Yatra, you can also visit and experience the divine Panch Kedar, Panch Prayag and Panch Badri. In the Panch Badri, Lord Vishnu is worshipped in various unique forms



IN FOCUS



A pedestrian walking on a rainy day in Shimla, Himachal Pradesh PTI

CBSE launches parenting calendar for 2026-27 session

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) on Wednesday launched the 'Parenting Calendar' for the academic session 2026-27, aimed at strengthening structured engagement between schools and parents and promoting students' holistic well-being.

The calendar was launched through a live event streamed on CBSE's official YouTube channel, with participation from school principals, teachers, counsellors, wellness educators and parents.

"In alignment with the vision of the National



Education Policy (NEP) 2020, CBSE had undertaken this initiative in the academic session 2025-26 with a clear objective to strengthen the partnership between parents and schools and to promote holistic student well-being," the board said in a statement.

The board said the initia-

tive received an encouraging response and witnessed active engagement from stakeholders across the country, reaffirming its relevance, efficacy and impact.

Building on the feedback, the 2026-27 edition expands the framework with enhanced engagement strategies, teacher-led activities and focused psycho-social interventions to support students' emotional, social and academic development.

"Building on this momentum, the CBSE Parenting Calendar 2026-27 further strengthens and expands this vision by institutionalising structured engagement between schools and

parents. The current edition introduces enhanced engagement strategies, teacher-led activities and focused psycho-social initiatives to support students' emotional, social, and academic growth, while addressing challenges faced by parents in today's evolving environment," the statement read.

New components have been added to improve its scope, including dedicated sections on inclusion to promote equitable practices for diverse learners, and "coping with changes" to help parents and students adapt to evolving curriculum and academic expectations.

UP pioneers 10-year O&M warranty for RWS under Jal Jeevan Mission



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Lucknow

Uttar Pradesh has become the first state in India to introduce a mandatory 10-year Operations and Maintenance (O&M) "warranty" for rural drinking water schemes (RWS) under the Jal Jeevan Mission. The move marks a shift from construction-focused projects to a long-term, service-oriented and community-driven approach.

The initiative is supported by the 'Jal Arpan' programme, under which villagers are not just beneficiaries but active stakeholders—taking ownership of water systems as managers and protectors. This model is designed to ensure sustainability and accountability in delivering safe drinking water.

Officials said construction agencies will work closely with Gram Panchayats over the next decade, providing technical support and guidance to maintain the Har Ghar Jal initiative. The approach reflects Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision of Jan Bhagidari (people's participation) for Jan Kalyan (public welfare), with strong backing from Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath.

Under the new framework, executing firms are contractually responsible for operating and maintaining water

supply systems for ten years. This includes ensuring regular performance, repairs, and infrastructure upkeep. The reform addresses past challenges where schemes failed due to poor maintenance, unpaid electricity bills, and limited community involvement.

To reduce operational costs, Uttar Pradesh has installed over 33,000 solar-powered water schemes, cutting expenses significantly while promoting environmental sustainability.

Village Water and Sanitation Committees (VWSCs), or 'Paani Samitis', have been empowered to manage daily operations. These committees are involved from planning to maintenance and are supported through training programmes focused on system management and water quality testing.

The state has also expanded its water quality monitoring network, including district and mobile laboratories. A Citizen Charter is being introduced to ensure service standards, while an online grievance system and helpline enable timely complaint resolution.

With these reforms, Uttar Pradesh aims to create a sustainable, community-managed rural water supply system, ensuring reliable access to safe drinking water for the future.

PM Modi to inaugurate Sardardham Bhavan in Vadodara on May 11

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Vadodara

Prime Minister Narendra Modi is scheduled to visit Vadodara on May 11 to inaugurate the newly constructed Sardardham Bhavan in Central Gujarat.

The invitation for the inauguration ceremony was extended by Sardardham president Gagji Sutariya, who, along with trustees, recently met the Prime Minister in New Delhi. The visit comes shortly after the conclusion of Gujarat's local self-government elections.

Earlier, there were speculations that PM Modi would travel to Ahmedabad to cast his vote during the local body polls. However, he put those rumours to rest by voting via postal ballot from Delhi.



During his upcoming visit, the Prime Minister is expected to receive a grand welcome in Vadodara. A special felicitation programme is also being planned, which will see the participation of members of the Patidar community and other dignitaries.

The inauguration of Sardardham Bhavan is being seen as a significant event for the region, highlighting the growing socio-cultural infrastructure in Central Gujarat.

Jaishankar, Iranian FM Araghchi discuss West Asia situation, agree to stay in touch

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

External Affairs Minister (EAM) S Jaishankar on Wednesday held a detailed phone conversation with his Iranian counterpart Seyed Abbas Araghchi, discussing the evolving situation in West Asia, according to official statements from both sides.

In a post on X, Jaishankar said he had received a call from Araghchi and that the two leaders reviewed various aspects of the current regional developments. He added that both sides agreed to remain in close contact amid the ongoing tensions.

"Received a phone call from Foreign Minister Seyed Abbas Araghchi of Iran this evening. Had a detailed conversation about various aspects of the current situ-



ation. We agreed to remain in close touch," Jaishankar wrote. The Iranian Embassy in New Delhi also confirmed the exchange, stating that the two ministers discussed recent developments related to the ceasefire, bilateral relations, as well as regional and international issues.

"During a phone conversation between Seyed Abbas Araghchi, Foreign Minister of Iran, and

Subrahmanyam Jaishankar, Minister of External Affairs of India, the two sides discussed and exchanged views on the latest developments related to the ceasefire, bilateral relations, as well as regional and international issues," the embassy said in a post on X. The conversation comes against the backdrop of continuing tensions across West Asia. Araghchi recently concluded a three-nation

tour covering Pakistan, Oman and Russia as part of Tehran's diplomatic outreach. During his visit to Russia, Araghchi met President Vladimir Putin in Saint Petersburg, where the Kremlin reiterated its support for peace efforts in the region. He also held talks with Russian Foreign Minister Sergei Lavrov.

Sharing details of his engagements on X, Araghchi said he was "pleased to engage with Russia at the highest level" at a time when the region is undergoing significant changes. "Recent events have evidenced the depth and strength of our strategic partnership.

As our relationship continues to grow, we are grateful for solidarity and welcome Russia's support for diplomacy," he said.

NSO survey: Healthcare access and insurance coverage surge

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The findings from the National Statistical Office (NSO) 80th Round Household Consumption: Health survey highlighted a significant increase in healthcare access across the country, supported by targeted Government interventions, expansion of public health services, and increased insurance coverage.

Covering both rural and urban areas across the country, the survey canvassed 1,39,732 households, including 76,296 in rural areas and 63,436 in urban areas, thereby offering robust and ground-level insights into healthcare access, affordability, and utilisation patterns.

The findings of the NSO 80th round are underpinned by the Government's sustained increase in public investment in the health sector over the years, the health ministry said in a statement.

Enhanced budgetary allocations have enabled significant expansion of healthcare infrastructure across primary, secondary, and ter-

tiary levels, strengthened human resources, and supported the scaling up of key initiatives focused on preventive, promotive, and curative care, the statement said.

The median out-of-pocket medical expenditure (OOPE) per hospitalisation case in 2025 was Rs 11,285, indicating that over half of the country's hospitalisations involve relatively low expenditure. The report stated that only a small number of high-cost cases push up the average (mean value).

This shows that high expenditure is not widespread but limited to specific cases requiring specialised treatment. Moreover, the OOPE in more than half of the entire hospitalisation cases in public health facilities incur only Rs 1,100, the report said.

Importantly, for non-hospitalisation (outpatient) care, the median OOPE in public health facilities is zero, reflecting that a large proportion of citizens can access essential healthcare services entirely free of cost, it stated.

The Government's Free Drugs Service Initiative (FDSI) and Free Diagnostics Initiative (FDI), launched in



2015, have ensured the availability of free medicines and diagnostic services to people even in the remotest areas of the country.

This paradigm shift in primary and essential healthcare accessibility is also aided by over 1.84 lakh Ayushman Arogya Mandirs (AAMs) situated across the country, which significantly expands the scope of comprehensive primary healthcare, the statement said.

These centres are also leveraging digital health innovations to improve access. Strengthening diagnostics through the in-house hub-and-spoke model with sample transportation has improved the accessibility and availability of diagnostic services across different healthcare tiers.

Further, the Affordable

Medicines and Reliable Implants for Treatment (AMRIT) initiative, which has over 220 pharmacies across 29 States and Union Territories, provides more than 6,500 drugs at discounts of up to 50 per cent on market rates, significantly improving treatment affordability, the statement said.

These gains have been further reinforced by Ayushman Bharat Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana (PM-JAY) and other targeted Government interventions, which have enhanced access, reduced financial barriers, and strengthened trust in public healthcare systems, it said.

Encouragingly, this enhanced affordability has coincided with a substantial increase in healthcare demand.

The Proportion of Population Reporting Ailments (PPRA) has nearly doubled between the 75th and 80th rounds from 6.8 per cent to 12.2 per cent in rural areas and from 9.1 per cent to 14.9 per cent in urban areas, signalling improved awareness and a decisive shift towards proactive health-seeking behaviour, the survey report said.

The survey also captured an important epidemiological transition, with a decline in infectious diseases and a rising prevalence of non-communicable diseases such as diabetes and cardiovascular conditions.

This reflects the impact of sustained Information, Education and Communication (IEC) efforts, intersectoral convergence through community-based platforms such as Village, Health, Sanitation and Nutrition Committees (VHSNCs), and large-scale screening initiatives at the primary care and community levels.

In response to rising demand, utilisation of public healthcare facilities has strengthened, particularly

for outpatient care in rural areas, where utilisation has increased from 33 to 35 per cent. This improvement is attributable to the expansion of comprehensive primary healthcare services, with an emphasis on preventive, promotive, and early diagnostic care, supported by the availability of free drugs and diagnostics.

Financial risk protection has expanded significantly with the rapid scaling up of Government-financed health insurance coverage, including under Ayushman Bharat Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana (PM-JAY) and various State schemes.

The percentage of the population covered under these Government health-financed/insurance schemes in the country has increased from 12.9 per cent to 45.5 per cent in rural areas and from 8.9 per cent to 31.8 per cent in urban areas, representing more than a threefold expansion.

This marks a major milestone in safeguarding vulnerable populations against catastrophic health expenditures and advancing equity in healthcare access, the statement said.

India, Italy to review defence ties in Delhi talks



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India and Italy will review the entire spectrum of their defence ties during talks in New Delhi on Thursday between Defence Minister Rajnath Singh and his counterpart Guido Crosetto, the defence ministry said on Wednesday.

Giving details, officials said during the bilateral talks, the Ministers will discuss a range of issues covering defence cooperation between the two countries. They are also expected to share their views on regional and global issues in view of the evolving security landscape.

Defence cooperation between India and Italy gained further momentum after Rajnath Singh visited Rome in October 2023. Defence Minister Crosetto's maiden visit to India underlines the desire of both nations to further expand existing cooperation and explore new areas of collaboration, particularly under the industrial partnership domain. The signing of the India-EU Defence and Strategic Partnership in January 2026 signals increasing strategic convergence and has provided further impetus to defence industrial cooperation in areas of mutual interest.

ISI's new surveillance tactic relies on dhabas

The use of digital tools and local recruits makes detection challenging", the official added.

The National Investigation Agency (NIA) in concert with the state police forces, has taken over the probe into the linked inter-state terror module. The probe gained momentum following a major counter-terror operation in Jammu and Kashmir on April 7, 2026, during which five terrorists linked to the Pakistan-based Lashkar-e-Tayyiba (LeT) were arrested.

The network is tied to a broader inter-state terror module involving radicalisation and recruitment of local youths into sleeper cells. All five accused including two Pakistani nationals are currently in custody and undergoing detailed interrogation to unravel deeper connections, funding channels and operational plans.

This arrest is being viewed as a vital breakthrough but agencies suspect it is only the tip of a larger, Pan-India operation. The central agency's involvement underscores the national security implications as the module is believed to have a decentralized structure with local operatives acting as eyes and ears for ISI handlers.

Multiple states have augmented security apparatus in response to fresh intelligence

alerts by the central security agencies. Intelligence warnings about infiltration routes, including Nepal, have been issued periodically, aligning with the heightened Bihar alert.

Bihar police issued a specific alert on April 24, 2026, directing all districts to remain extra vigilant against suspected ISI operatives attempting to establish semi-permanent bases along the highway network, particularly near sensitive military installations.

Sleeper cells are reported to be active across regions stretching from Kashmir to Delhi-NCR and parts of Uttar Pradesh. Authorities in Uttar Pradesh are particularly concerned ahead of the 2027 Assembly elections, with inputs suggesting possible attempts to orchestrate incidents that could create unrest and destabilise the region.

Other states are enhancing checks on commercial setups near strategic locations, focusing on suspicious patterns in ownership, CCTV installations, or unusual activity at dhabas and shops. Increased patrols, surveillance and local intelligence monitoring have been stepped up.

Separately, the NIA has taken over investigations into Pakistan-linked spy networks using CCTV cameras to target sensitive sites in the NCR and beyond, indicating a surge in hybrid espionage efforts combining physical surveillance with digital transmission of feeds to handlers in

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Pakistan. "The development serves as a reminder of the persistent cross-border challenges India faces, particularly in border states and along critical transport corridors", intelligence sources say.

As the NIA digs deeper, further details on ISI module's funding, handlers and exact targets may emerge. For now, the focus remains on disrupting the network and preventing any exploitation of India's highways as unwitting tools in espionage campaigns.

Exit polls give BJP edge in West Bengal, win...

Assam and Puducherry surpassed their highest-ever poll participation by recording a voter turnout of 85.38 per cent and 89.83 per cent respectively. Tamil Nadu went to polls on April 23 along with the first phase of polls in West Bengal. Tamil Nadu with 84.69 per cent recorded their highest-ever voter turnout in Assembly polls since Independence.

While the BJP is seeking to retain power in Assam and Puducherry, where it is in an alliance Government with All India N R Congress, the Congress is looking to wrest power from its rival in both these places.

In Kerala, the Congress-led UDF is seeking to

replace the LDF Government that is in power, while in Tamil Nadu, the DMK-led alliance is looking to retain power by thwarting the challenge from AIADMK-BJP and the debutant party — Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam that is led by actor-turned-politician Vijay.

Devotion to disrespect: Reel culture disrupts...

I am shocked to have noticed ever liquor bottles thrown away in the precincts of the temple, which I never saw during so many years of service to Baba here," a priest told *The Pioneer* who wished not to be named.

According to him, the situation of chaos started over the last three-four years, and the public understands that Kedarnath is a picnic spot. "It is not a picnic spot. It is a powerful centre and Jyotirlinga," he said.

More than 11.4 lakh pilgrims had visited the temple last year, and the Kedrantah Yatra is said to have generated a revenue of about ₹300 crore for the local economy in terms of travel modes like helicopters, mules, horses, palanquins, hotels, dhabbas, florists, guesthouses, etc. Last year also certain cases of public nuisance at the holy shrine had surfaced.

To reach Kedarnath temple in Rudrapryag district, one has to travel by road till base points like Phata, Gaurikund via Haridwar and Sonprayag, followed by trekking of about 14 km traversing the Gangotri group of hills in Western Garhwal Himalayas. Mules, horses, palanquins, and helicopter services are also available from base points for the pilgrimage period of about six months, between the last week of April or the first week of May till the end of Diwali in the same year.

PM sees win in West Bengal

"I am confident that in the elections in these five states, the BJP is going to complete a historic hat-trick of victories. The results of May 4 will strengthen the resolve for a developed India. They will infuse new energy into the pace of the country's development," the Prime Minister further said.

With the second phase of voting in West Bengal coming to an end, the current poll season comes to an end, as voting has already concluded in Tamil Nadu, Kerala, Assam and Puducherry. Results for all four states and the Union Territory will be declared on May 4.

Working to restore peace in State since assuming office: Manipur CM

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Imphal

Manipur Chief Minister Y Khemchand Singh on Wednesday said that since assuming office in February, he has been engaging with MLAs, officials and members of different communities to work collectively for the restoration of peace in the State.

Speaking at the inauguration of five infrastructure projects in Langthabal constituency of Imphal West district, Singh said peace remains the foremost prerequisite for development, urging people to remain united in achieving lasting harmony.

“Over the last two months and twenty days, I have held



extensive interactions with legislators, Government officials and community representatives to foster reconciliation and stability. I have visited both hill and valley regions, including Jiribam, Senapati, Kangpokpi and Ukhrul districts, to hear public

grievances and assess local issues,” he said.

Calling the recent incidents of violence unfortunate, Singh said those responsible would be identified soon.

He appealed to the people to maintain communal harmony and remain vigi-

lant against forces trying to create division.

The chief minister also said development work would continue across all regions, despite existing challenges, and called for cooperation between the people and the Government to build a peaceful and progressive Manipur.

During the programme, Singh inaugurated three water supply projects and two community halls in the Langthabal constituency.

Deputy Chief Minister Losii Dikho praised the CM’s outreach efforts, including visits to remote areas such as Jiribam, Senapati and Ukhrul. He said Singh has adopted a unique approach by personally meeting people from different communities and listening to their concerns.

Last Mizo insurgent group to lay down arms

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Aizawl

A total of 43 members of the Lalhmingthanga Sanate-led faction of the HPC(D) will lay down arms in Mizoram on Thursday, officials said.

Chief Minister Lalduhoma and Home Minister K Sapdanga will attend the event at the Police Central Training Institute in Sesawng, around 40 km from Aizawl, they said on Wednesday.

The ‘homecoming ceremony’ follows the peace accord signed between the Mizoram Government and the Hmar People’s Convention (Democratic) on April 14, effectively marking the end of insurgency in the State.

Though largely dormant in recent years, the Sanate-led



Members of the Hmar People’s Convention (Democratic) FILE PHOTO

HPC(D) faction was considered the last surviving ethnic insurgent outfit in Mizoram and was allegedly involved in sporadic criminal activities, including extortion in Hmar-dominated villages.

The agreement, signed at Sakawrdai in Aizawl district-headquarters of the Sinlung Hills Council (SHC) - focuses

on the comprehensive development of the Hmar-majority SHC region. Key provisions include higher budgetary allocations for the council, a special development package, infrastructure upgrades and improved connectivity.

The HPC(D), in its charter of demands, sought transfer of

SHC administration from the General Administration Department to the District Council and Minority Affairs Department, establishment of project and agriculture offices in Sakawrdai, increased annual budgetary support from 2027-28, and special development works.

It also demanded official recognition of the Sikpui Ruoi festival and Hmar Martyrs’ Day on May 16 as holidays in the SHC jurisdiction, which covers 31 villages in northern and northeastern Mizoram, bordering Assam and Manipur.

Other demands included construction of internal roads, an Eklavya Model Residential School, and a Netaji Subash Chandra Bose Awasiya Vidyalaya hostel.

Ashwini Vaishnaw to flag off Srinagar-Katra Vande Bharat

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

The twin Capital cities of Jammu and Srinagar will now be directly connected with smooth and safe travel following the launch of the Vande Bharat Express service from Jammu on Thursday. Union Minister for Railways Ashwini Vaishnaw is set to flag off the extended Srinagar-Katra Vande Bharat Express from the refurbished Jammu Tawi Railway Station.

While flag-off marks the inaugural run, the extended Jammu Tawi-Srinagar Vande Bharat Express will enter regular service from May 2, 2026. Two pairs of services will operate across the corridor, covering a distance of



around 266 km.

Following the flag-off, the Union Minister will subsequently inspect two of the most remarkable engineering structures on the Udhampur-Srinagar-Baramulla Rail Link (USBRL), the Anji Bridge and the Chenab Bridge.

When Prime Minister Narendra Modi flagged off the Katra-Srinagar Vande Bharat Express on June 6, 2025, the train ran with 8

coaches. Since then, the train has consistently been running at full capacity, with an overwhelming response from passengers. The decision to augment the rake to 20 coaches is a direct response to that demand, more than doubling the train’s seating capacity at a stroke, and significantly easing the pressure on reservations and waitlists, particularly during peak pilgrimage and tourist seasons.

The extension is expected to give a significant boost to tourism across the entire J&K corridor, making the region accessible to a far broader segment of travellers who may have been deterred by the logistics of the journey.

Ladakh groups urge Amit Shah for meeting on statehood in Leh

MOHIT KANDHARI ■ Jammu

The members of the two prominent representative bodies, spearheading a campaign in support of statehood for Ladakh and the extension of the Sixth Schedule of the Constitution to the region, have set their eyes on the visit of the Union Home Minister Amit Shah to Leh to pay respects to the sacred relics of Lord Buddha on Buddha Purnima.

The combined leadership of the Leh Apex body (LAB) and the Kargil Democratic Alliance (KDA) have also appealed to the Union Home Minister to hold deliberations with them during his two-day-long stay in the region.

Addressing a joint press conference after their internal meeting, LAB co-chairman Chering Dorjay Lakruk



appealed to Home Minister Amit Shah to hold detailed discussions with the LAB and KDA during his visit to Ladakh for meaningful dialogue.

“Shah once said that he will chair the High-Powered Committee (HPC) meeting. It’s time for him to hold the meeting,” he said, adding they are not expecting much from the May 22 Subcommittee meeting called

by the Union Home Ministry as it has limited people and can’t take big decisions, especially on their demands for Statehood and Sixth Schedule status.

Lakruk told local reporters in Leh that they have submitted their document on Statehood and Sixth Schedule status, which the MHA has studied as well. “Now is the time for them to react,”

he added.

The LAB co-chairman said if the MHA doesn’t agree to their demands, their struggle will continue.

Meanwhile, a Kargil-based political activist, Sajjad Kargili, on Wednesday issued a statement in which he said the recent decision of the Government to create five new districts in Ladakh — raising the total from two to seven — appears less an administrative reform and more a calculated attempt to fragment the unified democratic and statehood movement of the people of Ladakh, particularly the collective voice of both Buddhists and Muslims.

Kargili said the process has clearly ignored regional sensitivities, demographic realities, and principles of equitable representation. As per the 2011 Census, Ladakh

has a population of 2,74,289, of which approximately 46.40 per cent are Muslims and 39.65 per cent are Buddhists. However, the current reorganisation results in five Buddhist-majority districts and only two Muslim-majority districts. This disproportionate distribution reflects a deeply skewed and discriminatory approach, undermining the spirit of fairness and inclusivity.

He said, “We strongly oppose this arbitrary and insensitive restructuring. In particular, we reiterate the genuine and long-pending demand for granting district status to Sankoo-Suru and Shakar Chiktan. The people of these regions have repeatedly submitted memorandums to the Government, presenting justified and well-founded demands, yet they have been consistently ignored”.

Mamata faces ultimate litmus test, BJP eyes breakthrough

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

Forty-six days after the Election Commission of India (ECI) announced West Bengal’s Assembly polls on March 15, the State’s fiercest political contest in years ended on Wednesday with record voter turnout, the lingering controversy over SIR deletions, and competing claims of victory — turning the election into something far larger than a routine battle for power.

This election is no longer merely about who reaches Nabanna, the State secretariat. It is a referendum on whether Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee, after 15 years in power, remains Bengal’s central political figure, and whether a fourth straight victory can firmly establish her as the strongest Opposition face against the BJP before the 2029 Lok Sabha polls, or whether the saffron party has finally found a road to power in Bengal, before failing repeatedly.

With 92.47 per cent cumulative polling across the two-phase Assembly elections — 93.13 per cent in the first and 91.66 per cent in the second phase — West Bengal has recorded its highest-ever voter turnout since Independence, surpassing even the 84 per cent polling

in the 2011 election that first brought Banerjee to power and ended 34 years of Left Front rule.

The scale of participation delivered the first unmistakable political message: Bengal voted as if it believed power itself was at stake. In a State where elections are often read as emotional referendums as much as electoral exercises, the turnout transformed this contest from a routine fight for office into a larger verdict on political legitimacy, leadership and the future direction of the State. For Banerjee, this election is perhaps the defining battle of her political life. After three successive terms and a decade and a half at the helm of Bengal politics, she is fighting not just to retain power, but to defend the political order she built.

Few leaders embody their party as completely as Banerjee does. The distinction between Banerjee and the TMC has long blurred into near-complete overlap.

In 2021, when the BJP mounted its most aggressive assault with Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Home Minister Amit Shah leading a full-spectrum campaign, Banerjee fought back almost single-handedly on a wheelchair, with her leg in plaster, turning personal injury into a political



metaphor. That victory elevated her beyond a regional chief minister and strengthened her stature as perhaps the strongest non-BJP Opposition face nationally.

But 2026 is a more difficult battle. In 2021, Banerjee fought as a wounded but defiant incumbent, turning personal injury and the BJP’s all-out assault into political advantage. In 2026, she faces a heavier burden — not just anti-incumbency, but the accumulated fatigue of 15 years in power, corruption allegations, recruitment scams and growing questions over governance.

“This election is about protecting Bengal’s political identity. If Didi wins again, it proves that welfare politics and Bengali pride can defeat communal polarisation,” a senior TMC minister said.

For Banerjee, victory would mean far more than securing a fourth straight term. A defeat, however, would be existential. Unlike cadre-driven national parties, the TMC has no parallel centre of gravity beyond her.

For the BJP, Bengal remains unfinished political business. The party believes the moment may finally be ripe to breach what many call its “final ideological frontier” by capturing power in West Bengal — the birthplace of ideologue Syama Prasad Mookerjee and a state that remained the Left’s impregnable citadel for decades.

Since its 2019 Lok Sabha breakthrough, the BJP has treated Bengal not merely as another electoral target, but as a test of political completion.

From barely four per cent vote share in 2011, it surged to

nearly 40 per cent in 2019 and then won 77 seats in 2021, displacing the Left and Congress as the TMC’s principal challenger.

But the harder task has always been converting electoral expansion into Governmental power. Its 200-plus claim in 2021 collapsed, and the 2024 Lok Sabha target of crossing 30 seats again fell short.

“For us, Bengal is unfinished political business. From Syama Prasad Mookerjee to today, this is about completing a political journey,” a state BJP leader said.

If phase-I tested whether the BJP could retain its northern strongholds, phase two was the real examination: whether it could breach the TMC’s southern fortress. Of the 142 seats that voted on Wednesday, the TMC had won 123 in 2021.

Yet beneath turnout figures lay the election’s deepest undercurrent — the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.

With nearly 91 lakh names deleted statewide, almost 12 per cent of the electorate disappeared before polling began. Numerically, it changed the arithmetic. Politically, it changed the chemistry.

and poorer voters. The BJP defended it as a long-overdue cleansing of bogus entries.

In many constituencies, deleted names exceed previous victory margins, ensuring the battle over who was allowed to vote may continue even after polling ends.

Political analyst Biswanath Chakraborty said SIR changed both arithmetic and emotion. “Elections are not decided by subtraction. They are decided by the psychology created by that subtraction,” he said.

“The election is no longer just about seat arithmetic; it is about whether Mamata Banerjee remains the central political fact of Bengal. If she wins again, it places her at the centre of national opposition politics,” Chakraborty added.

For the BJP, Bengal is the last major ideological frontier. A victory here would be read nationally as proof that even Bengal’s exceptional political culture can be breached, he said.

The results will be announced on May 4, when Bengal will know whether Banerjee’s long political dominance still holds its electoral grip, or whether the BJP has finally found a way to turn years of ambition, organisation and ideological pursuit into power at Nabanna.

Nation Focus



ARMY CHIEF VISITS PENTAGON TO BOOST DEFENCE TIES

Army Chief General Upendra Dwivedi recently visited the Pentagon in the US and held discussions with senior military officials seeking to bolster defence cooperation and explore new avenues for collaboration in capability development and joint operations, officials said on Wednesday. The Chief of the Army Staff was on an official visit to the US from April 20 to 23. “In a significant boost to India-US military ties, General Upendra Dwivedi visited the Pentagon on April 23, reinforcing strategic cooperation between the two armies,” a senior official said.



DEGREE TO BE ON DIGILOCKER AFTER RESULTS, SAYS PATIL

Students in Maharashtra may soon receive their degree certificates well before convocations, as the State Government has directed the universities to upload them on DigiLocker immediately after the results are declared, a minister said on Wednesday. The move is aimed at avoiding delays in getting degree certificates to students, he said. DigiLocker is a cloud-based platform that provides digital document wallets to citizens, enabling the storage, issuance, and verification of authentic documents. State Higher and Technical Education Minister Chandrakant Patil said many students apply to foreign universities, higher education institutions, scholarships, internships and employment opportunities soon after their results are declared.

CPI lambasts Odisha Govt over tribal repression

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The National Secretariat of the Communist Party of India (CPI) on Wednesday lashed out at the Odisha Government, accusing it of unleashing “repression” on tribal communities to facilitate corporate mining interests. The party demanded an immediate halt to land acquisition in Rayagada and a high-level probe into a “shocking” incident of administrative apathy in Keonjhar.

In a statement issued on April 29, the CPI alleged that the district administration in the Sijimali area of Rayagada is acting as an “agent” of Vedanta Resources. The party claimed the State Government is violating established laws to push for development at the cost of tribal rights over ‘Jal, jungle, and Jameen’ (water, forest, and land).

“It is deeply alarming that in Sijimali, where the Gram Sabha has repeatedly and unequivocally rejected permission for mining - approval that is legally mandatory - the administration continues to push ahead,” the statement read.



The CPI noted that final clearances from Forest and Environment authorities are still pending and pointed out that the Odisha High Court has already raised concerns regarding the Gram Sabha process.

The party further highlighted a harrowing incident from the mineral-rich Keonjhar district - the home district of Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi. The CPI cited the case of Jeetu Munda from Dianali village, who was reportedly forced to carry the skeletal remains of his sister to a bank due to administrative indifference.

“This incident lays bare the inhuman and insensitive functioning of the State machinery and exposes the hollowness of the Government’s tribal-friendly claims,” the party stated.

The CPI has demanded that the Odisha Government immediately withdraw mining projects being imposed against the will of the people and halt all attacks on innocent tribals.

States Focus



RAJASTHAN CM URGES ACTIVE PARTICIPATION IN CENSUS

Rajasthan Chief Minister Bhajanlal Sharma on Wednesday urged residents of the State to actively participate in the upcoming Census exercise, calling it a "constitutional duty" and a "national responsibility". Sharma said the Census is not merely a data-collection exercise but a crucial process that helps shape the nation's future. "The Census is a great national endeavour that determines the direction of the country's development. Citizens should treat their participation as an opportunity to contribute to nation-building and social justice," he said. The chief minister said enumerators will be required to travel long distances in Rajasthan, as it is the largest State geographically and urged people to cooperate with them during the exercise.



LG MANOJ SINHA REVIEWS SECURITY SITUATION IN J&K

Jammu and Kashmir Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha on Wednesday reviewed the security situation and preparedness for the upcoming Amarnath Yatra at a meeting here, official sources said. The security review was held ahead of the annual 'Darbar Move', with the secretariat scheduled to close in the winter Capital Jammu on April 30 and reopen in Srinagar on May 4. The meeting, chaired by Sinha, was attended by senior Army, police, security, intelligence and administrative officials, including Director General of Police Nalin Prabhat, sources privy to the matter said. It focused on law and order management and coordinated security arrangements, they said. The overall security scenario in Jammu and Kashmir was reviewed, with particular emphasis on ensuring the safe and smooth conduct of the annual Amarnath Yatra, a major pilgrimage that draws thousands of devotees every year.

High drama in Bhabanipur as Mamata, Suvendu take swipes

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee and Leader of the Opposition Suvendu Adhikari landed in the same polling booth area in Bhabanipur's Chakraberia on Wednesday morning, and took swipes at one another without any direct interaction, underlining the prestige battle unfolding in the CM's political bastion.

Though they did not come face-to-face or exchange courtesies, the two rival candidates were briefly in the same area in ward number 70 of Chakraberia, where Banerjee was seated outside a local party office after receiving complaints of alleged intimidation of local



TMC leaders.

As Banerjee remained on the verandah of the party office, Adhikari arrived on the road, just opposite the spot, accompanied by a large contingent of central forces



personnel, and launched an attack on the chief minister, claiming she had realised that "not a single vote" was coming her way.

While Banerjee accused the BJP of trying to "rig" the elec-

tion using central forces, police observers and election officials, Adhikari dismissed her allegations as signs of "frustration", saying the chief minister was "scared" because State police no longer controlled the polling process.

"Banerjee is scared. Her police have been replaced by central forces, which is why she is scared. The ECI has deployed CAPFs here, so if she has any problem, she should approach them. Why have 40-50 people come with her?" Adhikari said.

He claimed Union Home Minister Amit Shah had also called him. Adhikari also accused Banerjee of moving around with "50-60 goons" despite prohibitory orders under Section 163 being in force.

BJP hails high voter turnout as sign of change in West Bengal



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

Senior BJP leaders on Wednesday expressed satisfaction over what they described as strong voter enthusiasm across West Bengal, saying it augurs well for 'Paribartan' (change) in the State.

BJP State president and Rajya Sabha MP Samik Bhattacharya, Union Minister of State Shantanu Thakur, senior leader Dilip Ghosh and actor-turned-politician Mithun Chakraborty echoed similar views while interacting with the media, stating that people exercised their democratic rights without fear or intimidation.

Ghosh, who is contesting from Kharagpur Sadar, told reporters that the presence of central forces was necessitated as the "situation in West Bengal turned worse than Kashmir."

"TMC goons used to attack Opposition candidates and intimidate voters previously, but they can't anymore. Now, everywhere there is a violence-free and fear-free atmosphere, and credit goes to the Election Commission of India (ECI)," he told reporters.

"People of the State now yearn for 'Paribartan' and removal of the TMC regime," he said. Echoing him, Bhattacharya told reporters, "After 50 years, people of West Bengal have voted in

such a way, where the usual scene of intimidation, threat to voters outside polling booths by ruling party leaders was missing. Everyone has come forward to cast their votes. Whoever you like to vote for, exercise your right freely."

Thakur said Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee's "false claims about high-handedness of central forces and the ECI will not work anymore, as reflected by the high voter turnout across the State in the earlier first phase and the present second phase.

"In Falta, the TMC candidate was threatening voters. The special police observer of ECI went there to instil confidence among voters, and polling is taking place peacefully in a fair manner. Mamata Didi's game is over," he said.

Actor and BJP leader Mithun Chakraborty, who cast his vote in Belgachia, said he voted "like an ordinary voter" standing in the queue without seeking any special facilities.

"I do not want any facility. I voted like a common voter," Chakraborty told reporters after casting his ballot.

Expressing confidence over the polling turnout, he said, "I hope, watching the trend, voting will be higher than 90 per cent. And if that happens, you can predict what will happen," hinting at a possible change of guard in the State Government.

Mamata accuses central forces of working for BJP in West Bengal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee on Wednesday alleged that the central forces, deployed for Assembly polls, were working in favour of the BJP and claimed that the ongoing State elections were not being conducted in a free and fair manner.

After casting her vote at Mitra Institution school in her Bhabanipur constituency, Banerjee launched a sharp attack on the central forces, alleging that her party workers and polling agents were being intimidated and driven out of booths.

"The atrocities by the central forces are unprecedented.



West Bengal CM and Trinamool Congress (TMC) candidate from Bhabanipur constituency, Mamata Banerjee, after casting a vote in the second and final phase of the West Bengal Assembly elections at a polling station in Kolkata on Wednesday

What is happening is not at all free and fair polls," she said.

The TMC supremo alleged that central forces, instead of performing their constitutional duty, were being used for partisan political purposes.

"Central forces are supposed to guard the country's borders, but instead they are working for a particular party," she said, without naming the BJP.

Banerjee also accused the forces of harassing voters

and TMC workers across several constituencies.

"The central forces are torturing common people. It is like brutalising the democracy. Is this an example of free and fair polls?" she asked.

Banerjee claimed that TMC workers were being targeted. "They have assaulted so many of our cadres and have forced our polling agents to leave the booths," Banerjee alleged.

The chief minister had, earlier in the day, visited several polling booths in the Bhabanipur constituency, including those in Chetla, Padmapukur and Chakraberia area, after receiving complaints from local TMC leaders over alleged intimidation and irregularities.

700 CAPF companies to stay in West Bengal post-poll: ECI

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

Around 700 companies of the Central Armed Police Forces (CAPF) will continue to remain deployed across West Bengal after the completion of polling, an Election Commission official said on Wednesday.

The continued presence of the central forces is aimed at maintaining peace and ensuring that no untoward incidents take place in the post-poll period, he said.

"As per the ECI's deployment plan issued on March 19, after completion of poll today, 700 companies of CAPF shall continue to remain deployed in the State for security arrangements and law and order duties, till further orders," he said.

"The forces will be stationed in sensitive areas and will assist the State



DG CRPF GP Singh visiting Chetla Bhabanipur Booth on Wednesday

PIONEER PHOTO

administration in maintaining normalcy," he added.

Union Home Minister Amit Shah had on Monday said that central forces would stay in Bengal for 60 days after the polls.

Officials said further decisions on the duration and scale of deployment

would be taken based on ground assessments and inputs from security agencies. West Bengal voted for 142 seats in the second phase on Wednesday, while polling for 152 seats in the first phase was held on April 23. The votes in all 294 Assembly seats will be counted on May 4.

TMC alleges central forces baton-charged voters

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

TMC Rajya Sabha MP Sagarika Ghosh on Wednesday alleged that central security forces baton-charged civilians, including women and a child, near a polling booth in South 24 Parganas district during the West Bengal elections.

In a post on social media, Ghosh accused the forces of "unbelievable violence" and claimed that after baton-charging women, the paramilitary personnel did not relent and went on "hitting and injuring a child".

Ghosh added, "This is unacceptable. Those responsible must be brought before the law."

She also criticised the role of the Centre, taking aim at Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Home Minister Amit Shah, alleging that such incidents were being carried out under their watch.

Though Ghosh did not name the constituency, she referred to the lathi-charge by forces on women and others at Falta in the district.

A senior ECI official said security forces lathi-charged a group — consisting of both men and women — outside a booth in the Belsingh area of



TMC Rajya Sabha MP Sagarika Ghosh

Falta following allegations of an attempt to influence voters.

"After repeated appeals to disperse, the forces took action to disperse the crowd and detained two persons in connection with the incident," the official said.

Protesters, however, alleged that the security personnel carried out an unprovoked baton charge, injuring several women voters standing in a queue outside booth number 186. They also claimed that a child accompanying his mother sustained head injuries.

The ECI official said a report has been sought, and if the child was found to be injured and the involvement of any security personnel was found, action will be taken.

Rahul Gandhi calls Great Nicobar project the biggest scam

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Sri Vijaya Puram

Senior Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Wednesday alleged that the Great Nicobar project at Campbell Bay in Andaman and Nicobar Islands was "one of the biggest scams and gravest crimes against the natural and tribal heritage of the country".

Stating that the project would entail the axing of millions of trees on 160 sq km of rainforest, and calling it a "destruction dressed in development's language",



LoP in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi during a visit to Shree Singh Sabha Gurdwara, Campbell Bay, Andaman and Nicobar Islands

PTI

the Leader of the Opposition in Lok Sabha said he would

raise the issue in Parliament. In a social media post,

Gandhi said, "I travelled throughout Great Nicobar today. These are the most extraordinary forests I have ever seen in my life. Trees older than memory. Forests that took generations to grow. The people on this island are equally beautiful - both the Adivasi communities and the settlers — but they are being robbed of what is rightfully theirs."

"The Government calls what it is doing here a 'project'. What I have seen is not a project. It is millions of trees marked for the axe. It is 160 sq km of rainforest

condemned to die. It is communities that have been ignored while their homes have been snatched away. This is not development. This is destruction dressed in development's language," he said.

"So, I will say it plainly, and I will keep saying it: what is being done in Great Nicobar is one of the biggest scams and gravest crimes against this country's natural and tribal heritage in our lifetime. It must be stopped. And it can be stopped — if Indians choose to see what I have seen," Gandhi added.

Assam polls: 8,500 officials to count votes on May 4

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Guwahati

Around 8,500 officials will be engaged for the counting of votes on May 4 for 126 Assam Assembly constituencies that went to polls on April 9, the State's Chief Electoral Officer Anurag Goel said on Wednesday.

Addressing a press conference, he said the Election Commission of India (ECI) is fully geared up to conduct the counting process smoothly and in a transparent manner.

"We will have 40 counting centres spread across the 35

districts of Assam. Most of the districts have a single centre comprising all the constituencies in their jurisdictions," Goel said.

Kokrajhar, Tinsukia and Jorhat will have two counting centres each, while Nagaon will have three such facilities, he said.

"The ECI has deployed 126 counting observers, who are senior IAS officers and will come from outside the State to maintain the neutrality of the process. We will also have 2,348 micro-observers, who are Central Government employees," Goel said.

For the main counting



work, a total of 5,981 people, mostly from the State Government, will be engaged as counting officials, he said.

A record 85.96 per cent of Assam's 2.51 crore electorate exercised their franchise

across 126 seats on April 9. This marked the highest voter turnout in the State's history, surpassing the pre-rivry high of 84.67 per cent recorded in 2016.

Regarding the security

arrangements, Goel said 25 companies of Central Armed Police Forces (CAPF) have been deployed across the State in the innermost cordon to guard the strong rooms, and they will also be stationed in the counting centres.

"In addition, we have 13 companies of State armed police stationed outside the strong rooms as the second cordon. We can say it with full confidence that the strong rooms have not been compromised," he said, refuting allegations of security lapses in the EVM storage facilities by some Opposition leaders.

RG Kar victim's mother faced TMC protests during polling



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

BJP's Panihati candidate Ratna Debnath, also the mother of RG Kar rape-murder victim, faced protests by TMC workers when she visited a booth in the Assembly constituency in West Bengal's North 24 Parganas district, where polling was underway on Wednesday. She also accused the ruling party activists of preventing her from leaving the booth premises, following an altercation with them over an allegation of influencing voters.

"When I was coming out of the booth, I noticed an elderly woman who looked infirm and had difficulty walking. I requested those present there to help the person cast her vote. But as I stepped out, TMC activists accused me of influencing the voter and prevented me from leaving the spot," she told reporters.



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‘Godman’ Kharat remanded in judicial custody till May 12

A Nashik court on Wednesday remanded self-styled astrologer-cum-godman Ashok Kharat in judicial custody till May 12 in the seventh case of sexual exploitation registered against him.

Kharat allegedly sexually exploited several women and indulged in large-scale financial fraud by claiming to have divine powers and knowledge of black magic. In the seventh case, he is accused of sexually exploiting a married woman who had approached him in search of solutions to her family problems. The accused allegedly gave the woman something to drink, sexually assaulted her while her husband sat outside his office and threatened to kill her if she told anyone about it.

On Monday, the court sent Kharat into the custody of the Special Investigation Team (SIT) till Wednesday in this case. He was produced in the court on Wednesday at the end of his police custody.

Due to security reasons, the court proceeding were held through video conferencing. During the hearing, the police demanded judicial custody for Kharat. Later, the court remanded him in judicial custody till May 12.

Kharat has been at the centre of a political firestorm, as he was well-connected. His photographs with political leaders and other important members of society have been surfacing since his arrest on March 18 after a woman alleged that he had repeatedly raped her for three years.



Excise case: Delhi High Court lists next hearing on May 4

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Wednesday said it will hear on May 4 the CBI's petition against a trial court order discharging former Delhi chief minister Arvind Kejriwal, his deputy Manish Sisodia and 21 others in the liquor policy case.

Even as the AAP leaders boycotted the hearing before Justice Swarana Kanta Sharma, the judge granted them one final opportunity to file their replies.

After Justice Sharma dismissed their applications seeking her recusal in the case on April 20, Kejriwal



and Sisodia wrote a letter to Justice Sharma earlier this week, stating they would not appear before her personally or through a lawyer and would follow "Mahatma Gandhi's path of Satyagraha". Former AAP MLA Durgesh Pathak also wrote a similar letter to the judge on Wednesday.

During the hearing, Justice Sharma said the court was

Approve maternity leave for third pregnancy: HC to Tamil Nadu Govt

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

The Madras High Court has held that no discrimination could be shown by the Government in approving maternity benefits, especially leave for the third pregnancy to the employees.

A division bench comprising Justices R Suresh Kumar and N Senthil Kumar gave the ruling on April 28 while allowing a petition from Shayee Nisha.

The bench set aside the orders of the Principal District Judge, Villupuram, dated March 27, 2026, which rejected the representation of the petitioner seeking maternity leave from



February 2, 2026 to February 1, 2027 and the Motor Accidents Claims Tribunal, Villupuram, which asked her to rejoin on April 27, 2026.

The bench directed the district judge to consider the application submitted by Nisha and sanction the



Hate speech: No intervention warranted, says SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Wednesday said the existing framework of criminal law adequately addresses the issue of hate speeches and no "legislative vacuum" exists warranting intervention.

"The contention that the field of hate speech remains legislatively unoccupied, is misconceived," a bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta said in its verdict on a batch of petitions related to hate speeches.

The top court said it would be open to the Centre and the competent legislative author-

ities to consider in their wisdom whether any further legislative or policy measures were warranted in light of the evolving societal challenges or to bring about suitable amendments as suggested by the Law Commission's 267th report of March 2017.

"While we decline to issue directions of the nature sought, we deem it appropriate to observe that the issues relating to hate speeches and rumour-mongering bear directly upon the preservation of fraternity, dignity and Constitutional order," Justice Nath said while pronouncing the verdict.

The apex court said cre-



ation of criminal offences and the prescription of punishments lies squarely with the legislative domain.

It said the Constitutional

tours of criminal liability through judicial directions.

"The precedents of this court consistently affirm that while Constitutional courts may interpret the law and issue directions to secure the enforcement of fundamental rights, they cannot legislate or compel legislation," the bench said.

It said the existing framework of substantive criminal law, including the provisions of the erstwhile Indian Penal Code, and allied legislations adequately addresses acts that promote enmity, outrage religious sentiments, or disturb public tranquillity.

"The field is, therefore, not

unoccupied," the bench said.

It said the statutory framework under the erstwhile Code of Criminal Procedure (CrPC), now the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS), 2023, provides a comprehensive and layered mechanism to set the criminal law in motion.

The bench said the duty of police to register an FIR upon disclosure of a cognisable offence is mandatory and in cases of non-registration of FIR, the CrPC or the BNSS provides efficacious remedy.

The detailed judgement is awaited. The top court had reserved its verdict on the pleas on January 20.

How can a non-believer in North claim right of entry to Sabarimala, SC asks

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

How can a non-believer in North India claim the right of entry to the temple in Sabarimala? The Supreme Court questioned on Wednesday and said that while deciding the issue regarding the right to enter temples, it has to examine whether a devotee or a non-devotee is claiming that right.

The observation of a nine-judge Constitution bench came while hearing petitions related to discrimination against women at religious places, including the Sabarimala temple in Kerala, and on the ambit and scope of the religious freedom practised by multiple faiths.

The bench comprised Chief Justice of India (CJI)



Surya Kant and Justices BV Nagarathna, MM Sundresh, Ahsanuddin Amanullah, Aravind Kumar, Augustine George Masih, Prasanna B Varale, R Mahadevan and Joymalya Bagchi.

Senior advocate Indira Jaising, appearing for two women named Bindu Ammini and Kanakadurga, who are supporting the 2018 judgement, submitted that

ing the Sabarimala Ayyappa temple and held that the centuries-old Hindu religious practice was illegal and unconstitutional.

"Today we are told that non-caste Hindus can enter Sabarimala, but not women," she said. But, because of Article 17, all men can enter, with no restriction of caste, she added.

The bench responded to the submission that the woman was not prevented because she belongs to the scheduled caste, but she was stopped as the female belonged to the 10 to 50 age group.

During the hearing, Jaising submitted that exclusion of women in the Sabarimala temple operates during the most productive and creative period of her life, that is, between 10 and 50.

SC disposes of Setalvad's plea for release of passport



Social activist Teesta Setalvad

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Wednesday disposed of activist Teesta Setalvad's application seeking release of her passport and said she may file a fresh plea as and when she fixes the itinerary to travel abroad.

Setalvad had sought the release of her passport that was deposited in a court as a bail condition in a matter of alleged fabrication of documents to frame innocent people in post-Godhra riot cases of 2002.

Her application came up for hearing before a bench of Justices Dipankar Datta, Satish Chandra Sharma and Alok Aradhe.

"Are you scheduled to go out anywhere soon? As soon as you (Setalvad) fix your itinerary, you let us know. We will not return the passport like this," the bench told senior advocate Kapil Sibal, who was appearing for Setalvad. "You have to tell us that you have to visit this country or that country. For travelling abroad, you want your passport back. For that, you need to make out a case," the bench observed. Sibal said Setalvad has to take permission from the court to travel abroad. While disposing of the application, the bench said, "However, as and

when the petitioner desires to travel abroad, she may file a fresh application." On April 13, the apex court had said that Setalvad's application may be listed before a three-judge bench after obtaining an order from Chief Justice of India Surya Kant as the bail was granted by a three-judge bench. Sibal had then argued that one of the conditions imposed for bail was that her passport would continue to be in the sessions court's custody.

On July 19, 2023, the top court granted her regular bail in the case involving alleged fabrication of documents to frame innocent people in the post-Godhra riot cases, while terming the Gujarat High Court order denying her the relief "perverse" and "contradictory".

Quashing the July 1, 2023 order of the high court, the three-judge bench had held that Setalvad's custodial interrogation was not necessary since the chargesheet in the matter was filed and most of the evidence was documentary in nature.

It had directed that Setalvad's passport, which she had already surrendered, would be in the custody of the sessions court and that she shall not make any attempt to influence the witnesses and stay away from them.

Delhi court acquits man of rape charges

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court has acquitted a man of charges of repeatedly raping a woman, who had alleged that he established physical relations with her after a false promise of marriage, with the judge saying that evidence pointed to a consensual relationship that turned sour.

Additional Sessions Judge Vishal Pahuja was hearing a case against Bilal Ahmed alias Sheelu, who was accused under IPC sections 376 (punishment for rape), 376(2)(n) (repeated rape) and 506 (criminal intimidation), along with charges under the BNS, relating to causing miscarriage.

The judge noted that the relationship continued for nearly three years and the complainant did not lodge any complaint during that period or disclose the allegations to family members.

In an order dated April 13, the judge said, "This court has no hesitation to conclude that the deposition of the prosecutrix which is full of infirmities and inconsistencies, has



rendered her testimony wholly unreliable."

"The shaky evidence, which is only oral in nature, cannot be formed a basis of conviction in this case. None of the offence charged against the accused has been proved in this case," it added.

According to the prosecution, the complainant alleged that she met the accused in December 2022, after which they became friends and entered into a relationship.

She claimed the accused promised to marry her and established physical relations with her on that assurance on multiple occasions.

Charges under PMLA provisions against Shabir Shah's wife

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court has ordered the framing of charges against Bilquies Shah, the wife of Kashmiri separatist leader Shabir Shah, in a 2007 money laundering case related to alleged terror financing, saying there was a prima facie case against her.

Bilquies is accused of receiving ₹2.08 crore from co-accused Mohd Aslam Wani. In an order passed on Tuesday, Additional Sessions Judge Shefali Barnala Tandon said, "At the stage of charge, the court is required to assess whether the material placed on record discloses



Shabir Shah's wife Bilquies Shah

es a grave suspicion against the accused warranting framing of charge."

She said the "material procured by Enforcement Directorate (ED) during detailed investigation in the form of relied upon documents, statements of the witnesses and of accused persons recorded are sufficient to show prima facie case and create grave suspi-

cion against the accused Dr Bilquies Shah under sections 3 and 4 (offence and punishment for money laundering) of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA)."

The court ordered framing charges against her under Sections 3 and 4 of PMLA.

These sections are for offences involving any direct or indirect participation in processes connected to "proceeds of crime".

The court posted the matter for formal framing of charges on May 20.

A court here has already framed charges against the co-accused, Shabir Shah and Aslam Wani, in the case in November 2017.

Obscene content disrupts Delhi HC proceedings

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A hearing through videoconferencing in the Delhi High Court was disrupted on Wednesday after a participant played obscene content on the virtual platform.

Additional Solicitor General Chetan Sharma mentioned the incident before a bench of Chief Justice DK Upadhaya and Justice Tejas Karia, seeking action to stop the circulation and dissemination of the recordings of the incident.

The chief justice said



appropriate directions have been issued to the registrar general on the administrative side in the matter. Sharma said such episodes damage the sanctity and overall integrity of the court. "There has been a disconcerting incident or incidents in the pre-lunch session, I gather, in some courts, not in one court," he said. Chief Justice Upadhaya said recordings of court proceedings were prohibited under the high court rules, and if any unauthorised content was circulating, the authorities would detect the same.

Our objective is to give houses to 22,000 Unitech homebuyers: SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court made it clear on Wednesday that its objective was to ensure that 22,000 homebuyers of the ailing Unitech Ltd got their dream homes and asked the new Centre-appointed board of the real estate group, banks and financial institutions to give suggestions for an amicable resolution of the long-pending dispute.

A bench comprising Justices JB Pardiwala and KV Viswanathan also asked the

counsel for the homebuyers and the land-owning agencies to furnish a two-page note giving suggestions to it within a week.

Around 22,000 homebuyers have been waiting for houses booked with Unitech for several years. A Government-appointed board has since taken over the management of the real estate firm.

On Wednesday, Additional Solicitor General N Venkataraman, appearing for the Unitech board of directors, referred to the financial



difficulties and the roadblocks faced by the board. The law officer said that the present board be allowed to withdraw and let a new board take over the affairs of

the firm and deal with pressing issues, including the delivery of nearly 22,000 dwelling units to homebuyers.

"The object is to give homes to homebuyers," the

bench said, adding that some kind of amicable solution has to be found.

Besides three asset reconstruction companies (ARCs), the bench asked seven banks and financial institutions to suggest measures to deal with the impasse.

It referred to the fact that as of now, the total outstanding of the company is ₹14,129.85 crore. During the hearing, the bench asked where the monies deposited by the homebuyers had gone. The law officer said the former promoters of the firm

parked the money in tax-haven countries.

The bench said it had thought of a solution and listed the plea after a week to pass some orders in the case that has been pending since 2016.

Earlier, the bench said it would take a serious view of non-compliance of its orders by any state authorities in matters related to the real estate group and cautioned them against creating hurdles in the completion of the stalled housing projects.

On January 16 last year,

coming to the rescue of thousands of homebuyers and facilitating disbursement of their stalled loans for flats constructed by Unitech, the top court granted exemption from registration under the RERA for different housing projects located in seven states.

It had said the order passed in the interest of justice would help in dispensing with the procedural requirements for releasing and advancing of loans to homebuyers of different Unitech projects.



Editor's
TAKE

India's aviation hits an air pocket

Without decisive reforms, the aviation sector risks remaining trapped in a cycle of boom and bust – grounded by the weight of its own inefficiencies

The Indian aviation sector presents one of the biggest paradoxes of the Indian economy. On one hand, air travel demand is on the rise, and on the other, airlines are failing. The story of Indian aviation has never been straightforward. It has seen many highs and lows, from the nationalisation of Air India and its subsequent sale to the mushrooming of airlines and their eventual disappearance from the Indian skies. The aviation industry has gone through a roller coaster ride. Right now, it is going through a very critical time, as many airlines are showing losses and are on the verge of closure. The rising fuel costs, coupled with a falling rupee –which makes maintenance and leasing of aircraft costly – along with high tariffs and bottlenecks at airports has put aviation sector at the crossroads.

The recent spike in aviation turbine fuel (ATF) prices, triggered by geopolitical tensions, has exposed the vulnerability of the aviation industry. The situation is so grim that the Federation of Indian Airlines has issued a statement that many airlines may be forced to halt operations.

At the heart of the crisis lies the disproportionately high cost of ATF, which accounts for nearly 40 per cent of an airline's operating expenses, which is well above the global average.

The recent implementation of differential pricing, with a steep `73 per litre rise for international flights, has put extra pressure on airlines operating on long-hauls. Airlines such as Air India, IndiGo, and SpiceJet are particularly vulnerable on long-haul routes, where fuel consumption is significantly higher. However, fuel prices are only one part of a larger problem. Indian aviation also has to contend with heavy taxation, volatile currency fluctuations, and razor-thin profit margins.

The 11 per cent excise duty on ATF, coupled with state-level levies, makes fuel in India among the costliest in the world. Besides, Indian aviation, like any other industry, is very price-sensitive and highly competitive, often leading to irrational fare wars that undermine profitability. Most Indian airlines rely heavily on price-sensitive economy passengers. The high ticket costs in periods of high demand irks passengers, who are often forced to shell out far higher fares during peak seasons or last-minute bookings. In a bid to offset mounting losses, airlines sharply hike ticket prices, a practice that places an additional burden on travellers and fuels perceptions of unfair pricing.

The bottom line is that the government must not consider air travel as a luxury but as any other industry which must thrive and provide affordable services to its customers. The government must rework its tariff structures; if airlines make profits, they will be able to offer cheaper tickets, thereby adding more passengers, which will add to government revenue. Enhancing operational efficiency through better infrastructure and air traffic management must be given priority. The government must work on long-term policy framework - particularly on fuel pricing to encourage strategic planning. ATF taxation must also be rationalise by bringing it under the GST regime, to minimise cost burdens. These small steps can go a long way in uplifting the aviation industry.

From 'reluctant prince' to assertive challenger

As India's opposition regains institutional space after a decade, Gandhi's tenure is increasingly being judged not just by rhetoric in Parliament, but by his capacity to convert visibility into political credibility and sustained influence



KALYANI SHANKAR

Has Rahul Gandhi become a credible Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha since his appointment in June 2024? With nearly two years having passed, how effective has he been? Has he held the government accountable and changed his party's approach to budget reviews? Has he demonstrated leadership qualities such as strategic communication and coalition-building during this time? These questions are essential for evaluating his influence and effectiveness.

Rahul began his political career in 2004 and has faced both successes, challenges, and failures. He has worked behind the scenes, guiding the party through victories and defeats, while choosing not to take a ministerial role in the Manmohan Singh government from 2004 to 2014.

Gandhi's rise to a prominent position within the Congress Party was largely expected, reflecting his positioning within the party. He has the final say in party appointments. While many party members viewed his leadership as a positive development, others expressed concern that it highlighted the party's lack of alternatives and its dependence on the Nehru-Gandhi family. Ultimately, he resigned, and senior leader Mallikarjun Kharge became the party president.

Rahul's role as LOP has included pointing out the government's mistakes in Parliament and outside on behalf of the Opposition and his own party. However, there have been important occasions when he was not present.

Rahul has taken on a more assertive, visible role, focusing on defending the Constitution, addressing income inequality, and challenging the BJP-led government on various issues. He has rebranded his image to align with the formal role, focusing on job creation, safety for marginalised groups, and the rights of farmers.

This is the first time in a decade that a cabinet-level position has been filled. Since 2014, no opposition party has achieved the 10% of 543 seats needed to be recognised as the Leader of the Opposition. This presents a significant opportunity for the Opposition to challenge the Narendra Modi government. On his first day in the Lok Sabha as LOP, Rahul Gandhi stressed the need for the ruling coalition to uphold the rule of law and for the Opposition to address issues such as the economic downturn, unemployment, a caste census, and the farmers' crisis. As the Leader



GANDHI IS OFTEN REFERRED TO AS THE "RELUCTANT PRINCE" BY HIS CRITICS, WHO BELIEVE HE IS HESITANT TO FULLY EMBRACE THE RESPONSIBILITIES THAT ACCOMPANY HIS SIGNIFICANT INFLUENCE. HOWEVER, MANY CONSIDER HIM TO HAVE BEEN THE UNOFFICIAL NUMBER TWO IN THE PARTY FOR A LONG TIME

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The Pioneer

of the Opposition, he participates in selecting key officials, such as the Chief Election Commissioner and the CBI Chief, to ensure that the Opposition has a say in these appointments.

Rahul's presence in Parliament has become more confrontational and assertive, reflecting his strategic shift to challenge the government directly. With the ruling party loudly defending the Modi government, noisy scenes have ensued in Parliament. Still, it has also enabled the Opposition to oppose key bills, such as the Women's Reservation Bill and the farmers' bills. His active participation in legislative debates and initiatives demonstrates his growing influence and impact as Leader of the Opposition, consistently challenging the Modi government on multiple issues.

One successful step was his Bharat Jodo Yatra, which boosted his image by allowing him to mingle with the public and learn about their problems firsthand.

Educated at some of India's most prestigious schools, he went on to study economics in the United States and gain international experience working in London before returning to Mumbai in 2002.

Gandhi is often referred to as the "reluctant prince" by his critics, who believe he is hesitant to fully embrace the responsibilities that accompany his significant influence. However, many consider him to have been the unofficial number two in the party for a long time.

However, some were worried about the party's continued reliance on the Nehru-

Gandhi family for leadership.

Rahul decided to enter politics and won a seat in 2004 from Amethi. In September 2007, he became the party's secretary-general while his mother, Sonia Gandhi, remained president. By January 2013, he had risen to Vice-President of Congress, highlighting his growing influence.

Critics say that even though he is more visible now, the party lost key state assembly elections in late 2024 and 2025. This raises doubts about his

ability to turn popularity into votes.

Rahul became the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha in June 2024. As time passes, he could lose support if he fails to secure the backing of regional allies and continues to struggle in local politics. The Opposition created the INDIA bloc and worked together in the 2024 General Election. As a result, the Opposition won more seats. The Congress Party doubled its number of seats.

Additionally, there has been feedback regarding his attendance at key events and his focus on topics that some critics view as less significant. He is trying to be more approachable by engaging in activities that demonstrate his commitment to ordinary people's concerns. Different groups view his performance differently.

During Rahul Gandhi's tenure as Leader of the Opposition, he has become a more focused and articulate leader. However, whether he has gained "credibility" is subjective. Supporters see improvement, while opponents argue his style remains unchanged.

The Pioneer
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How human connections redefine workplace stress



APS MALHOTRA

2ND OPINION

It is my firm belief that workplace stress has been around in one form or another for ages. However, what has changed over time is its structure and intensity - the beast has starkly metamorphosed. Today, amplified by technology-driven jobs and laggard employment rates, stress has become a constant hum of fatigue, dissatisfaction, and the pressure to remain perpetually available. These anxieties rarely stay within the four walls of the office; rather, they sneak out surreptitiously into the outside world, magnifying personal, emotional, and physiological fault lines like never before. I have witnessed all these changes during my nearly four decades of corporate life experience.

My career—like those of many others - has had its share of tranquility and turbulence, highs and lows, shaped by hierarchies, interpersonal dynamics, and the often not-too-

subtle currents of power and politics. At times, professional strain collides headlong with personal worry, thereby creating an atmosphere of acute self-doubt, as happened with me during the COVID-19 pandemic, when my hypertension spiked sharply, as my daughter, Mehak, a young doctor, took her position on the front lines of the raging war across the seven seas. The ambiguity took a palpable toll on my health, to an extent that medication that had long been stable had to be increased suddenly.

It was in this state of apprehension that I took up a new assignment — after the lockdown had eased — anticipating the familiar, uncertain phase of adjustment. Instead, I was surprised by what I encountered — something that altered my understanding of workplace stress. There was, to begin with, an unusual lightness in the environment. And although work was taken seriously, the edge of fear that often accompanies it was absent. Soon, I fathomed that the difference lay largely in leadership, as the team lead laid emphasis on brevity and humility, preferring these over pomposity, exaggeration, and hype. Expectations were clear, but they were not enforced through intimidation, something that resulted in a culture of trust rather than anxiety. These positively charged winds received a further boost recently during a posting I worked on. It was here that I truly understood the equally important role of rela-

tionships. Within months of taking over, I established close bonds with a small group of colleagues at a similar stage in their careers as me - rushing speedily towards what in common parlance is referred to as 'senior citizen'. What began as shallow banter grew into genuine camaraderie — conversations that extended into shared experiences and reflections.

These connections created a sense of ease long missing in my professional life. Amid this came an unexpected - and most welcome - change: a routine medical check-up showed my blood pressure had dropped below normal levels, requiring reduced medication, while my diabetes indicators recorded their best readings in over a decade.

These are not mere coincidences but pointers to something of greater import - often overlooked in discussions on stress management, which tend to focus on individual coping mechanisms such as mindfulness, exercise, and time management.

While these matter, they are only part of the picture. The environments we work in, the leadership we experience, and the relationships we build play an equally decisive role. Workplace stress may be inevitable, but the way it shapes our lives is not.

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The writer is a corporate professional and an astute observer of everyday life

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Cooperate in fencing the border

The Calcutta High Court has strongly reprimanded the Govt of West Bengal for failing to hand over land for fencing along the India-Bangladesh border. Despite clear orders to transfer 127 km of already acquired land to the BSF, only 8 km has been handed over so far.

This raises serious concerns, as large stretches of the border have effectively remained unfenced and vulnerable, relying only on manpower instead of physical barriers for security.

The court termed the state's response evasive and inadequate, stressing that such delay in a matter of national importance is unacceptable. It demanded a detailed affidavit explaining the inaction.

The prolonged delay, despite funds and land availability, creates an impression of more than mere administrative lapse—suggesting possible deliberate inaction under the guise of inefficiency, with wider implications for national security and governance.

Fencing has been very effective in controlling cross border illegal migration and has curbed smuggling and trafficking in a big way. The State Govt must cooperate and do the needful so that border can be effectively safeguarded.

RS NARULA | PATIALA

Train looters on the prowl

Drugging train passengers and robbing them of their valuables is an old modus operandi of notorious gangs. The activities of the infamous "biscuit gang" is fresh in memory: looters targeted gullible travelers through biscuits laced with drugs. The effects of a few drugs are so severe that passengers often fail to regain consciousness for hours only to find their valuables stolen. These gangs, sometimes, appear suave and sophisticated with children in tow to give a "family touch".

The "activities" of the looter gangs are at its peak during festivals when trains are packed to their capacity. No doubt, refusing to accept food and drinks from strangers is the best way to be safe. However, an alert passenger should also have a keen eye to spot something fishy. Co-passengers should be extra-vigilant to spot the unusual. Some railway stations in India have a loud speaker announcement system to exhort passengers to be alert and active on trains. It would not be a bad idea for the RPF and GRP personnel to personally spread awareness among passengers. Recently, the police were able to apprehend a woman, besides others, for relieving passengers of their valuables on the Sainagar Shirdi-Kakinada express near Maharashtra's Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar which shows alertness can prevent such happenings.

GANAPATHI BHAT | AKOLA

FTA: Safeguard interests of farmers

Apropos to "FTA: Towards closer ties with New Zealand" published on 29th April, here is my response. India-New Zealand trade deal has the potential to strengthen economic ties between the two nations by promoting bilateral trade and investment. It will open new markets for Indian exporters, particularly in sectors such as textiles, pharmaceuticals, and information technology, while also providing New Zealand greater access to India's massive consumer base. New Zealand is known for its high-quality dairy and agricultural products, while India has a strong base in spices, tea, and processed foods.

A balanced exchange in these sectors could lead to mutual growth and improved food security. The FTA is expected to create employment opportunities and encourage innovation through increased collaboration in areas like education, technology, and renewable energy.

Strengthened trade relations will also enhance cultural exchange and deepen diplomatic ties between the two countries. But we should not overlook the concerns it will raise. The interests of domestic industries, especially small-scale farmers and local businesses, should be safeguarded. A well-negotiated deal must strike a balance between openness and protection.

BAL GOVIND | NOIDA

PIC TALK



People walk on a rainy day, in Shimla, Himachal Pradesh.

PHOTO: PTI

DIGITAL EXPERIENCE

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MAKE MAY DAY MATTER: FROM SYMBOLISM TO DIGNITY

May Day was born from workers' struggles for the eight-hour workday. Making it truly "great" today means moving beyond symbolism to ensure real dignity for labourers. In India, this requires not just speeches but concrete, everyday actions and stronger policy commitments. Basic safety remains a critical gap. Nearly 80 per cent of construction deaths are linked to head injuries, underscoring the urgent need for essential protective gear—helmets, gloves, boots – and access to drinking water. Employers must ensure timely wages, safe working conditions, and simple respect, including acknowledging workers with gratitude.

At a social level, meaningful change begins with recognition. Engaging with those who sustain our daily lives—security guards,

domestic workers, plumbers—understanding their families and aspirations, helps restore dignity to labour. A "great" May Day is not marked by banners, but by a society where a worker can afford education and security for their children.

Policy reforms must prioritise labour welfare through healthcare access, insurance coverage, and savings schemes. Construction workers, gig workers, farmers, and factory labourers form the backbone of the economy, yet remain among the most vulnerable. Ensuring their well-being is not charity – it is an economic and moral imperative. May Day must evolve from commemoration to commitment, where dignity, safety, and fairness define the true value of labour.

CR KRISHNA IYER | MUMBAI

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

Forest fires in India: A growing ecological and governance challenge

Despite advances in monitoring and policy frameworks, the scale, frequency, and consequences of these fires continue to grow, exposing critical gaps in prevention, governance, and long-term ecological planning



BKP SINHA | **ARVIND KUMAR JHA**

Every year, thousands of wildfires erupt across the globe, consuming vast stretches and degrading ecosystems while releasing significant quantities of carbon into the atmosphere. In India, they pose a recurring and systemic challenge — one that leads to habitat fragmentation, loss of the genetic pool, including that of most domesticated plants and animals, and disruption of rural livelihoods. They undo conservation gains while undermining ecological stability across regions.

The economic implications of forest fires are equally severe. A 2025 study estimates that annual losses - including timber, non-timber forest products, and carbon sequestration — amount to nearly ₹1.74 lakh crore. Satellite-based monitoring by the Forest Survey of India (FSI), using MODIS and SNPP-VIIRS systems, reveals that almost 36 per cent of the country's 8.27 lakh sq. km total forest cover is 'prone to frequent forest fires'. Data shows that between 2023 and 2025, the fire-affected area has increased by 16 per cent, while complementary data from the World Resources Institute and Global Forest Watch suggest that 44 per cent of India's tree cover loss between 2023 and 2024 was attributable to forest fires alone.

Forest fires, being of a predominantly ground-sweeping nature, except in some hill states like Uttarakhand, are generally considered low-impact events. Handled primarily by the Forest Department, forest fire is notified by the National Disaster Management Authority (NDMA) as a 'disaster'. The enormity and consequences of forest fires, however, indicate that they are different from sudden-onset disasters like earthquakes and floods. They are, in fact, 'foundational disasters' that can potentially act as a primary trigger for the devastation of the nation's natural capital and agricultural production, earthquakes due to hydro-seismicity caused by disrupted seasonal replenishment of the water table over successive years in the forest's 'benefitshed' areas, devastating flash floods and debris flows due to loss of forest cover and impermeability/soil hydrophobicity of the forest floor, increased human-wildlife conflict, etc. A relentless series of successive disasters with ecological and socio-economic collapse may thus unfold over time as a result of forest fires. Studies show that over ninety per cent of forest fires are anthropogenic and driven by traditional forest-based livelihoods, agricultural cycles, and commercial activities that follow seasonal ecological transitions. Thus, as months pass, successive forest fires from December onwards are caused due to the setting of fires for promoting grass growth for grazing, burning of the forest floor under mahua trees to facilitate flower collection, setting of fires to promote a fresh flush of tendu leaves, jhum cultivation, etc. There are also instances of forest fires due to the accidental jumping of sparks during preventive fire-line burning operations, deliberate setting of fires for generating employment in fire-fighting work, kindling of forests to take revenge on foresters, burning of bridle-path strips, setting fires for hunting smaller wild animals and keeping larger ones at bay, etc. The overall threat recedes with the monsoon before re-emerging in November, with agricultural stubble burning near forest fringes initiating the annual cycle of vulnerability. FSI's Alert-to-Detection (A/D) ratio analysis indicates distinct 'reason-specific signatures' of forest fires. It reveals that, transitioning from the capturing of small, scattered fires, the 'Large Forest Fire' (LFF) algorithm switches from point alerts to event tracking in March-April, keeping pace with the massive, systematic 'broadcast burning' for triggering the dormant buds of the tendu plant to produce better-quality leaves. The peak of India's fire season is thus dictated by commercial interests.

Despite the criticality and growing scale of the crisis, funding patterns indicate that the Centre's allocation for the Forest Fire Prevention and Management (FFPM) scheme has remained modest ₹40 crore, ₹35 crore, and ₹37.5 crore over the past three years. In contrast, the NDMA oversees a ₹5,000 crore scheme launched in July 2023 for the "Expansion and Modernisation of Fire Services", primarily designed for urban fire response. Some states are



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AT THE NATIONAL LEVEL, THE FSI CONTINUES TO PROVIDE CRITICAL BASELINE DATA ON FOREST FIRES. HOWEVER, EXPERTS ARGUE THAT ITS METHODOLOGIES REQUIRE SUBSTANTIAL UPGRADES. IMPROVEMENTS IN SATELLITE RESOLUTION, CLEARER DEFINITIONS OF FIRE EVENTS, AND A SHIFT BEYOND THE CURRENT "TREE COVER" PROXY ARE NEEDED TO ACCURATELY CAPTURE GROUND-LEVEL ECOLOGICAL DAMAGE

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using portions of these funds to procure wildland-urban interface equipment to prevent forest fires from spreading into human settlements. In early 2025, an additional ₹818.92 crore (including a central share of ₹690.63 crore) was allocated for forest fire mitigation across 144 high-priority districts in 19 states. Experts note that much of it remains focused on post-disaster response rather than long-term prevention strategies. Legal and institutional challenges make fire prevention and control on the ground difficult. Apprehending offenders in forest areas remains difficult, as forest guards often patrol alone and may not find witnesses to establish intent. Historically, the provisions of the Indian Forest Act, 1927 provided a strong legal deterrent against offences, including trespass and kindling a fire in a manner that endangers a forest. Trespass, being the first step before the commission of any other offence in the forest, and the fear of it being prosecutable, precluded the occurrence of many offences, including arson. The Jan Vishwas Act, 2023, aimed at decriminalising 'minor offences' to improve ease of living and doing business, has diluted penalties related to trespass and forest fires. With trespass becoming compoundable with a penalty of up to ₹500, the fear of imprisonment that served as a strong psychological and legal deterrent is gone. Similarly, leaving the country's ecologically "priceless" resource burning in a protected forest now attracts a penalty of up to ₹500. Experts warn that such minimal penalties are negligible "transaction costs" for offenders, particularly in activities like tendu leaf collection and trade.

Concerns have also been raised about the widespread grant of Community Forest Resource Rights under the Forest Rights Act, 2006 in ineligible cases, which has created erroneous perceptions regarding jurisdictional matters, ultimately leading to a visible decline in accountability for forest protection. Unfortunately, illegal grants continue to be facilitated by the creation of geospatial proxies through an improperly designed 'potential CFRR area Atlas' being prepared in various states. In this context, Gadchiroli district's reality of consistently recording the highest fire alerts, often overshadowed by the "success story" narrative, should be an eye-opener.

At the national level, the FSI continues to provide critical baseline data on forest fires. However, experts argue that its methodologies require substantial upgrades. Improvements in satellite resolution, clearer definitions of fire events, and a shift beyond the current "tree cover" proxy are needed to accurately capture ground-level ecological damage. Integrating fire detection systems with real-time ground assessments could significantly improve the effectiveness of enforcement. Any strategy for preventing forest fires must consider the complexity of the reasons behind them, the problems of the chronically depleted frontline workforce in the forestry sector, and the deepening paradox within India's statutory landscape.

As forest fires grow in frequency and intensity, India must move beyond reactive firefighting to a more preventive approach. This includes strengthening early warning systems and expanding public awareness. Given their role as 'gateway crimes' to encroachment and degradation, the decriminalisation of trespass and forest fires must be reconsidered. With commercial interests often involved, stricter legal provisions, penalties linked to biodiversity loss, and incentives for fire-free practices such as tendu management are essential. Further, auditing all CFRRs granted under the FRA to weed out illegal recognitions, empowering local institutions, strengthening frontline staff, and adopting AI-based predictive modelling for pre-positioning personnel in high-risk zones are necessary. The restructuring of the financial landscape to prioritise prevention over reaction must be undertaken, and adequate budgets must be provided for forest fire management.

To prevent forest fires from triggering a cascade of disasters, India must adopt a comprehensive strategy grounded in rigorous prevention, ecological restoration, unyielding legal deterrence, and institutional coordination without further delay. Without this, the nation risks accelerating environmental degradation, undermining the livelihoods of its forest-dependent communities, and the ecological decapitalisation of forest-dependent economies. The urgency is a categorical imperative, and the matter is simply non-negotiable.

AAP's shift: From common man roots to elite drift



RAJEEV KUMAR

The recent exit of seven members from the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) to align with the ruling dispensation has drawn sharp attention - not only nationally but within the party's leadership. Yet, given their socio-economic profiles, the development may be less surprising than it appears. A majority come from highly privileged or resource-rich backgrounds: Ashok Kumar Mittal, Rajendra Gupta, and Vikramjit Singh Sahney are linked with substantial wealth; Harbhajan Singh is associated with the financially powerful Board of Control for Cricket in India; and Raghav Chadha has strong connections across corporate and Bollywood circles. The remaining

figures - Swati Maliwal and Sandeep Pathak - have held significant internal influence within the party. Taken together, this group reflects a convergence of wealth, influence, and elite networks - raising a broader question about how such trajectories align with AAP's original common citizen ethos. Seen through the lens of their privileged and rich backgrounds, these moves appear less unexpected; in this context, even figures like Sandeep Pathak seem drawn towards the orbit of such privileged networks and their pursuit of prosperity.

The Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) emerged as one of the most compelling political experiments in post-liberalisation India. Born out of the India Against Corruption movement, it promised to disrupt entrenched political hierarchies by placing the "common citizen" at the centre of governance. Its appeal lay not merely in policy, but in identity - it sought to redefine politics as a space where ordinary individuals, rather than entrenched elites, could shape public life. This moral and political positioning distinguished it sharply from traditional parties and created a sense of credibility and hope among voters disillusioned with conventional power structures. The early success of the Aam Aadmi Party rested on a simple idea: politics should not be driven by pedigree, wealth, or inherited influence. It aimed to create space for volunteers, grassroots activists, first-time entrants, and honest professionals - marking a clear break from parties shaped by dynasties and elite networks. This principle was also visible in the leadership's conduct. AAP leaders maintained a simple, common appearance - blending into everyday public life. It reinforced their claim of sharing the realities and mindset of ordinary citizens. The model drew wide support, including among Indians working across the globe, many of whom contributed intellectually, financially, and emotionally to this experiment. The result was unprecedented: a relatively young political formation, still in its infancy, secured remarkable electoral success in Delhi, challenging long-entrenched political structures. However, early compromises in candidate selection - often justified as electoral necessity — led to dissatisfaction and the first signs of internal strain, including the exit of some founding members who saw a dilution of core ideals. In January 2018, the Aam Aadmi Party marked a clear shift in its Rajya Sabha selections: two of the three nominees, ND Gupta and Sushil Gupta, were from elite backgrounds - including one from a long-established national party - while only Sanjay Singh came from its grassroots leadership. This departure from its anti-elitist stance signalled a move towards privilege through a route often associated with influence and resources.

The decision triggered internal dissent, led to the exit or marginalisation of key founding members, and widened the gap between principle and practice. The shift did not remain isolated; it became a pattern. In April 2022, five selections from Punjab reinforced this trend: Harbhajan Singh, a well-known cricketer; two key party strategists, Raghav Chadha and Sandeep Pathak; and two individuals, Ashok Mittal and Sanjeev Arora, from influential or financially strong backgrounds. The July 2022 additions continued similarly: Vikramjit Sahney is a well-known elite, while Balbir Singh Seechewal is rooted in AAP ideology, though he declined to be associated with AAP. In January 2024 (Delhi), among the three nominees, the wealthy ND Gupta was re-nominated, and the highly privileged insider, Swati Maliwal, entered the Rajya Sabha. In October 2025, Sanjeev Arora's replacement from Punjab again brought in a wealthy candidate, Rajendra Gupta.

Across these cycles, selections consistently favoured individuals with visibility, influence, or economic capital over grassroots workers - indicating a sustained shift in which the Rajya Sabha became a channel for privileged profiles, reinforcing the party's ideological drift. The warning signs were clear, yet largely overlooked. In India, cricket and Bollywood are closely tied to affluent networks, and the trajectory of Raghav Chadha - already among the more privileged faces in the Aam Aadmi Party - became emblematic. His marriage into a well-connected Bollywood circle reinforced perceptions of deepening elite linkages, raising doubts about alignment with the "common citizen" ethos, especially within the elite setting of the Rajya Sabha. Observers noted his gradual distancing from grounded engagement. Interventions on everyday issues, though symbolically relevant, were seen as limited in substance compared to the lived realities of ordinary citizens. Despite such signals, the leadership response remained muted. Individually credible, these choices collectively point to a sustained reliance on privileged individuals over grassroots representation - suggesting that repeated wake-up calls went unaddressed, widening the gap between ideals and practice.

The pattern of "privileged exits" is not just about individuals - it stems from leadership choices. When people from elite backgrounds are brought in and later leave, it reveals a deeper internal mismatch: a repeated preference for influential or wealthy individuals (especially through the Rajya Sabha), centralised decision-making that limits grassroots voices, and a growing gap between the party's "common citizen" claim and its actual choices. The result is a clear mismatch - an anti-elite beginning but increasing acceptance of elite influence. The issue is not the inclusion of privileged individuals, but the lack of balance. What appears as defections is, in fact, the outcome of decisions that have gradually changed the party's character - raising the question: is this evolution or drift?

Despite multiple crises in the past, the Aam Aadmi Party has shown resilience - offering a clear opportunity for course correction. The priority now is honest internal introspection, not external blame, to realign recent choices with its founding ideals.

A key step is rebuilding a broad base of committed, grounded individuals - bringing back those who left due to organisational differences rather than ideology. Equally crucial is decentralising decision-making to reduce overdependence on a few individuals and to strengthen internal democracy and collective deliberation. If pursued sincerely, this can renew AAP's original promise of alternative, citizen-centric governance - strengthening institutions to function fearlessly, independently, transparently, and with accountability.

The writer is a Tech-Education Policy Consultant, a former Professor of Computer Science at IIT Kharagpur, IIT Kanpur, BITS Pilani, and JNU, and a former scientist at DRDO and DST

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From fear to fightback: MDR-TB Survivor's handbook lights the path to recovery



SWAPNA MAJUMDAR

"Hello! I'm Deepti Chavan and I am an MDR-TB survivor. I know how it feels to hear the words 'drug-resistant tuberculosis (DR-TB)'. When I heard them, my whole world changed. It can be scary and overwhelming. But let me assure you, you can recover. Like I did!" By pegging itself on the journey of Chavan, a well-known multi-drug-resistant (MDR) TB survivor, a recently launched handbook for DR-TB-affected individuals manages to stand out among the many resource materials on TB. It simplifies how to navigate the complexities of TB diagnosis and treatment through the lens of a survivor, thus resonating with scores of people, both affected and those afraid they may be affected. Incidentally, about 64 per cent of people with TB symptoms do not seek care due to stigma, ignorance, or affordability issues, leading to delayed diagnosis and continued transmission.

This is probably one of the reasons why TB continues to be India's biggest infectious



disease challenge. India contributes about 25 per cent of the global TB burden, with five countries together accounting for over half of all cases worldwide, according to the government's 2026 Tuberculosis Fact Sheet.

While TB services have expanded in the country, there is a lack of awareness that, despite being an infectious disease caused by a bacterium called Mycobacterium tuberculosis, TB can be completely cured with proper

diagnosis and timely treatment. In this scenario, knowledge and information are key. This is where the 16-page guide, developed by Survivors Against TB (SATB), a survivor-led network, can bridge the information gaps.

Besides drawing on tools and insights from the Stop TB Partnership, including resources such as the OnImpact DR-TB module and the TB Champions Toolkit, it has been enriched by the inputs of survivors like Chavan, advocates,

healthcare providers, and medical professionals. This makes it both factual and relatable, since it is a collaborative effort by those who have gone through the emotional roller coaster of fear, misgivings, and self-pity and have also managed to overcome these hurdles. Though 55,000 cases of DR-TB were reported in 2024, requiring longer and more complex treatment, the bigger positive picture underlined by the booklet is that there is no giving up, no matter how hard or long the journey may be, because there is always light at the end of the tunnel. The handbook not only lays out the TB roadmap, outlining how TB is transmitted and explaining treatment options, it also provides practical tips for TB-affected people and their caregivers. While addressing the most often asked question — "Why did it happen to me?" — the handbook makes it clear that it is nobody's fault and that it can happen to anybody. Chavan, being an MDR-TB survivor, explains in simple language the main types of drug resistance. Multidrug-resistant TB (MDR-TB) means the TB bacteria are resistant to rifampicin and isoniazid, the two most important anti-TB drugs used in treating TB.

If a person is diagnosed with rifampicin-resistant TB (RR-TB), this means their TB is resistant to rifampicin, with or without resistance to other drugs. In practice, RR-TB is treated in a similar way to MDR-TB. The third type is exten-

sively drug-resistant TB (XDR-TB). This is a more serious form of drug-resistant TB, in which the bacteria are resistant to several key TB medicines, including those used to treat MDR-TB.

Chavan reiterates that while dealing with drug-resistant TB can be overwhelming, and it takes more effort to treat than drug-sensitive TB, with the right medicines, consistent checks, and strong support, it is possible to recover, just as she did.

But for this, patients must access services. While scrolling to the "Health Facilities" section in the TB Aarogya Saathi app will aid in locating the nearest health centre, calling the RNTCP toll-free number (1800-11-6666) will help in finding testing and treatment locations and information on the nearest microscopy centre or DOTS centre. One of the most important facts underscored is the need for proper nutrition during the treatment journey. A balanced, nutritious diet rich in protein, vitamins, and minerals is crucial to fight the infection. The handbook points out that the government's Nikshay Poshan Yojana offers ₹1000 a month to help with nutrition costs during treatment.

The writer is a journalist writing on development and gender

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As the broader indices become volatile, and swing wildly each day, up and down a few thousand points, there is an exciting, but dangerous, sub-plot that is emerging in Indian equities. According to a recent report, even as main indices were down in March and April, and even before these months, the Nifty SmallCap 250 climbed by more than five per cent over the past two months. This, according to the writer, highlights a “stunning decoupling that suggests domestic retail investors are betting that geopolitical storm will pass before it hits (corporate earnings).” The rise in some of the stocks are unbelievable, more than 50 per cent in two instances. Between 35 per cent and 50 per cent in seven cases, and around 30 per cent in another nine stocks. Although most of these shares are in an obvious manner related to green energy, and renewables, there are some related to pharma, and even stock trading. Hence, they may have nothing to do with the expectations of when the war will end, and more with the implications after the war ends. Green energy is an obvious gainer. So is stock trading because investors wish to cherry pick at low prices.

According to some brokerage houses, since the large-caps and midcaps are beyond the reach of the small investors, even at highly-corrected prices, the enthusiasm is more focused on the small-caps. There is a belief that the future stock market trends will follow what happened during Covid. After the deep crash in March 2020, stocks across the world rebounded as if there was no pandemic, or that the pandemic was a blessing in disguise for several firms across sectors. But analysts warn against such beliefs, which may not turn out to be true. “A sharp rebound a la Covid-19 or the Russia-Ukraine war is unlikely as large global stimulus or unlocking pent-up demand is missing,” says a brokerage house. It adds that the incomes of individuals, firms, and nations are under pressure, investments are on hold or in decline, and credit is being shaped by gold and MSME loans. The last are merely “substitutes for weak income, and thus not increasing activity.” The pandemic unintendedly led to major cost cuts, partly due to the sackings and work-from-home, and the Russia-Ukraine war propelled Russia to push more oil into the market that subdued energy prices. This time, oil prices may remain high for months, even years.

At present, despite the net outflows by the foreign investors, there is substantial domestic money that is sloshing around, and looking for investment opportunities. Gold reached a peak, and its correction in January and March 2026 scared off investors, which is reflected in the quarterly demand for gold-backed exchange-traded funds (see the anchor article on this page). Large-caps, though stable and safe, are too expensive, and the possible losses are higher if indices go down further. In such a scenario, where tech, IT, and software stocks are at new lows, the obvious targets are the small-caps. They are cheap, and because the liquidity is low, prices move up sharply due to small purchases. The excitement about green energy, amid global crude oil prices at \$110 a barrel, encourage investors to seek small stocks in the sector. But as brokerage houses issue warnings about indices and stocks, and some of them downgrade India as a nation, compared to the Asian and emerging market peers, investors need to be careful. When the markets go up, if they do in some months, the small stocks may be left behind. As the same article concludes, the “divergence between small-cap exuberance, and large-cap reality is unlikely to hold indefinitely.”

In technical terms, one can contend that it is a question of valuations. According to a brokerage house, the midcap and small-cap valuations “remain more than one standard deviation above historical averages across metrics, and that the sharp earnings rebound the market is pricing, a 22 per cent profit CAGR (compounded annual growth rate) for FY-26-28, against just 12 per cent in the prior two years, is unlikely to materialise.” In fact, some analysts feel that the markets have lost the “valuation support,” and the initial indications of the quarterly results in the forthcoming Q1-27 are “already off to a weak start, with roughly seven per cent of Emkay’s (a brokerage house) coverage universe missing forecasts so far.” JP Morgan has slashed the FY-27 corporate earnings estimated by 2-10 per cent across sectors. The base case prediction for the Nifty 50 by the end of this year is 27,000, or 12.5 per cent up, with the bullish case at 30,000, or 25 per cent higher. Yet, there is the bearish case, which is at 20,000, 16 per cent lower. In such a scenario, two things can happen. Realities may finally bite as mentioned earlier, and force investors to seek safety. In such a scenario, the large-caps, if they do not go up substantially, or are dragged down, will pull down the midcaps and small-caps with them. In contrast, investors will swarm the small-caps, and forget about the large-caps, which may result in another divergence. There will be an interplay between excitement, exuberance, and earnings.

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | THURSDAY | APRIL 30, 2026

BUSINESS

10

Blame game between AI moguls

Tesla vs ChatGPT vs Anthropic, with media, public as participants

Over the past few weeks, verbal attacks, physical violence, media criticism, and fears among the masses have gripped the narrative related to artificial intelligence (AI). Even as Anthropic, the maker of Claude, has consistently, and indirectly, levelled ethical charges against OpenAI, the inventors of ChatGPT, the latter's founder, Sam Altman has blamed the media and the former's Dario Amodei for physical attacks on him. Tesla's Elon Musk, the richest man on Earth, has long hated Altman, and hurled another round of accusations in an ongoing trial. Even as the media questions the ethics, power, and influence of the AI moguls, the public seems scared of AI-related consequences.

Yesterday, Musk alleged that Altman, and his executives, stole OpenAI from the public, and converted a non-profit venture into a for-profit one. In a lawsuit that was filed in 2024 for the same reasons, Tesla's chief said that he co-founded OpenAI, and later left it or was forced to quit, to keep AI “away from the bad guys.” Although the phrase includes several hints about ownership, ethics, management, and strategies, the conclusions seem clear, and do not need to be spelt out. The eccentric, and controversial Musk is a positive antidote to Altman.

“It is not ok to steal a charity. If the defendants (Altman and OpenAI) are found not guilty, this case will become caselaw. It will give license to looting every charity in America. The consequences of this case go far beyond me or everyone here. The entire foundation of charitable giving in America will be destroyed,” Musk said in his critical testimony. In effect, the Tesla owner, who has faced several criticisms in the past, does not want the ‘tail to wag the dog,’ or charities and non-profit ventures to generate hundreds of billions for an individual.

Altman has been on the front foot to aggressively take on his rivals, both real and perceived. His most intense comments came after a scary incident. According to a media report, “Daniel Moreno-Gama traveled from Texas to California with the intent of killing Altman. Before he was arrested outside OpenAI's headquarters on the early morning of April 10 (2026), Moreno-Gama threw a Molotov cocktail (generally a bottle filled with petrol with a fire at the mouth which, when thrown, blows up) at Altman's \$27-million home.” The targets of Moreno-Gama included other “AI CEOs,” whose names remain secret.

Initially, as the OpenAI chief told a podcaster, he felt an “adrenaline shock,” which turned into despondency. “I was just, like, you know, there is gonna be more stuff like this, and it is incredibly disheartening. I went through a real depressive cycle about it. But it is very scary,” Altman added. During the podcast, and a blog post he wrote after the incident, the founder categorically blamed his rivals and media for the extreme public reaction. Although he did not say it specifically, it was clear that he felt that his image is being ruined for no valid reason.

Altman referred to a Shakespearean drama between the companies in our (AI) field” in the blog post, and suggested that a recent longform piece in the New Yorker magazine had made things more dangerous for him. In the podcast, he was more specific and direct. “I think the doomism talk has not helped. I think the way certain other labs talk about us has not helped. I think the way Anthropic talks about OpenAI does not help,” he claimed. The rivalry between the two firms started when they were start-ups. OpenAI released ChatGPT before Anthropic's

Claude because the latter was possibly too careful. Over the years, Amodei has blamed Altman for lack of safety, declaring ‘code reds’ regularly, and introducing ads in AI conversations. Altman poked fun at Amodei for the lack of focus on the masses, selling and serving “an expensive product to rich people.”

In reality, the war of words between the two is more about ethics and morality, what AI can and should do, and how to ensure that it serves public interest, and does not emerge as a rogue agent like social media has. Indeed, they refused to hold hands together when India's Prime Minister Narendra Modi urged several AI-Men to do it as a show of unity.

A long article in the New Yorker magazine supported Amodei's claims and fears. It raised “significant ethical concerns” related to Altman's management style, and decision-making process. There was an element of deception as “internal documents suggest that Altman misrepresented facts to the OpenAI's board and executives.” There were “misleading claims” related to safety protocols, and safety measures, which “potentially” compromised “ethical standards.” The investigative piece highlighted a long history, going back to the earlier times, of “manipulative behaviour in his leadership style,” which raised questions about trustworthiness, and the possible use of AI.

Despite taking the moral high-ground, and representing himself as a saint or AI-Messiah, Amodei has faced backlash from the media. A recent article in the Vanity Fair magazine poked fun at him, in a non-existent episode and interview that was laced with sarcasm and dark humour. According to the author, his make-believe meeting with the Anthropic founder went like this. For example, Amodei does not have a plan for the humans who may be displaced by AI, but dwells deeply on what it wants Claude, its AI, to do in an ethical manner.

When the interviewer asks Amodei about royalty for content used to train Claude, the founder says that such logic was mentioned when the firm was small. “The ethics got scaled down as valuation scaled up.” Anthropic and OpenAI and the rest build the “thing that creates the crisis, but solving it is someone else's problem.” Amodei talks about a super-intelligence that we cannot predict or control. “But he is building it anyway.” Finally, the writer clarifies that he never met Amodei. He fed Claude (AI) reams of content about Amodei, and the former churned out a credible version of an interview in three minutes.

The end result is a horrifying conclusion in a cover article in The Economist magazine, which states that five AI-men, including Musk, Altman, and Amodei, “hold the fate of Western civilisation in their hands.” It adds, “Plenty of people fret that it (AI) might end humanity altogether. Not since the splitting of atom has a new technology created such an angst.” Of these five men, a Ford or Rockefeller may emerge, who will control the fate of nations, and destinies of humans.

OUR TAKE

A Contrarian Investor

Bars shine, jewels lose sheen

Gold demand has slumped to the lowest in past four quarters

will happen in the future. One of the interesting sub-trends is the demand for bars and coins, which are essentially for long-term investment purposes.

In Q1-26, the purchase of almost 475 tonnes was the “second-highest quarter on record,” even as “Asian investors led the charge, hoovering up gold investment products.” On a year-on-year basis, the rise was more than 40 per cent, and almost 11 per cent on a quarter-on-quarter basis. Bars constitute almost 85 per cent of the buying in this segment, which includes coins, imitation coins, and medallions. Since Q2-25, the sale of bars zoomed by 60 per cent, largely driven by the price attraction.

In the future, according to the Council, “Asian demand will likely remain a key source of strength in investment, as concerns over global geopolitics fuels demand for effective risk hedges.” High prices, a lack of alternatives, and inflation may attract savers

and speculators. Unlike the investors in the West, the East-based buyers look at gold as something to be saved and preserved. The latter's holdings, which includes India and China, are over the longer term although, in the recent past, Indians have used gold as collateral to take loans to finance emergency, healthcare, and even consumption needs.

One is surprised that although the focus is on bars, gold jewels lost their sheen. This may indicate the smartness as investors feel that the returns from bars are higher because there are no cuts or discounts due to the making charges, as is the case with jewels, during sales. This explains why only the necessary spending, which is requisite in Asian marriages, festivals, and occasions, may have pulled down demand in the segment by 23 per cent, year-on-year, in Q1-26. The figure, at 335 tonnes, is the lowest in the past five quarters.

One can blame the quarter-on-quarter decline of more than 100 tonnes due to the marriage and festival season in Q4-25 (October-December). But then the Q1-26 figure is the lowest for the first quarter in seven years, with the lowest of 331 tonnes in Q1-20 for obvious pandemic-related reasons. In Q1-25, the purchases were 435 tonnes, or 100 tonnes more, but this figure was more than 100 tonnes lower than in Q1-24. There is something about the demand in the first quarters over the past several years, especially post-Covid, which follows the peak and highest demand in the fourth quarters of the previous year.

“Jewellery spend is likely to be resilient, absent economic shocks, but tonnage demand is expected to slip further as high prices, and regional tax policies, continue to bite,” states the World Gold Council. The fact remains that despite the lower volumes, the value of the quarterly spend in Q1-26 was up by 31 per cent, quarter-on-quarter, which indicates the continuance of “positive sentiment.” As mentioned earlier, people will buy jewels, but only what is required because of high purchase prices, and lower sale prices because of discounts.

ETFs and similar products were the quarterly laggards, with quarter-on-quarter sales dropping by more than 110 tonnes to 62 tonnes, with the highest at 230 tonnes in Q1-25. In Q1-22, the demand was 272 tonnes, followed by minimal or negligible purchases in Q1-23 and Q1-24. Hence, the first quarters are generally bad times for the ETFs. But this time, the Iran war created a crisis and scare, which pushed the US investors to withdraw from such investments, and logically led to “sizeable outflows from US funds in March (2026).” Hence, the future demand may be “positive but lower than in 2025.”

Which brings us to the central banks. They sold a lot of gold in the recent past, but bought more than 240 tonnes in the first quarter of this year, or the highest in the past five quarters. However, apart from a noticeable dip in Q2-25, when demand slumped to nearly 180 tonnes, the quarterly buying was between 200 and 240 tonnes. “Central bank buying is expected to be solid at levels close to those in 2025,” states the Council. But it does not rule out “tactical rebalancing.”

The Pioneer

SINCE 1865

Sensex, Nifty rebound nearly 1%

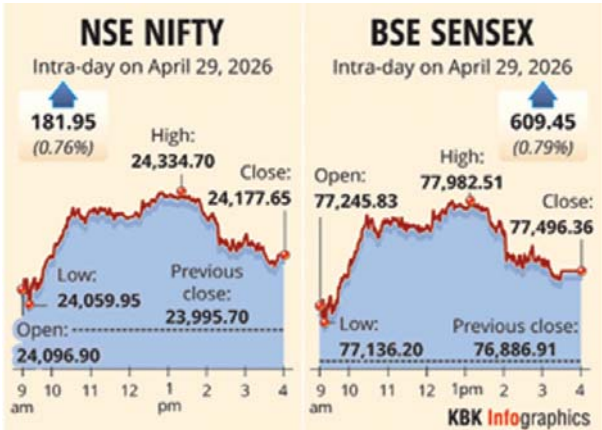
PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Equity benchmark indices Sensex and Nifty rebounded nearly 1 per cent on Wednesday, supported by bargain hunting in FMCG, auto and telecom stocks amid earnings optimism and a rally in Asian markets. Signs of potential de-escalation in geopolitical tensions also helped equity markets, traders said.

In a volatile session, the 30-share BSE Sensex jumped 609.45 points, or 0.79 per cent, to settle at 77,496.36. During the day, it surged 1,095.6 points, or 1.42 per cent, to 77,982.51.

The 50-share NSE Nifty climbed 181.95 points or 0.76 per cent to end at 24,177.65.

From the Sensex firms, ITC, Tech Mahindra, Maruti,



Reliance Industries, Bharti Airtel and Mahindra & Mahindra were among the biggest gainers. In contrast, InterGlobe Aviation, NTPC, Bajaj Finserv and ICICI Bank were among the laggards.

Maruti climbed 2.82 per

cent after the country's largest carmaker reported a record annual consolidated net profit of ₹14,679.5 crore in FY26, a year-on-year growth of 1.24 per cent, riding on its best-ever annual sales of over 24.22 lakh units, propelled by GST

rate reduction. In Asian markets, South Korea's benchmark Kospi, Shanghai's SSE Composite and Hong Kong's Hang Seng ended higher. Equity markets in Japan were closed due to a holiday.

"The core driver of today's strength remained earnings. Strong results from key companies reinforced confidence in underlying domestic demand and balance sheet resilience. This fundamental support, combined with easing geopolitical concerns, helped markets shift focus away from macro stress toward corporate performance," Hariprasad K, Research Analyst and Founder, Livelong Wealth, said. Hopes of potential de-escalation in geopolitical tensions helped stabilise crude oil expectations, which is critical for

India's macro outlook, he said. European markets were trading lower. US markets ended lower on Tuesday.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, jumped 2.85 per cent to \$114.4 per barrel.

"Despite weak global cues, elevated crude prices, and a depreciating INR, India's equity markets rebounded from recent lows as investors used the correction to add exposure, supported by better-than-expected earnings despite geopolitical uncertainty.

"Gains were led by FMCG, auto, and realty stocks on strong results and positive commentary, while financials lagged due to regulatory tightening and provisioning concerns," Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments Limited, said.

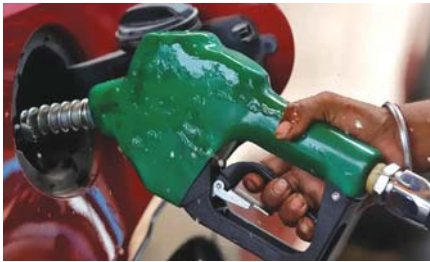
Oil firms selling petrol at ₹14 litre loss, diesel at ₹18

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Oil marketing companies are selling petrol and diesel at a loss of ₹14 per litre and ₹18 per litre, respectively, as elevated crude prices outpace capped retail fuel rates, squeezing marketing margins.

Besides losses on petrol and diesel, the elevated energy prices post West Asia crisis are likely to leave companies with an under recovery of ₹80,000 crore on cooking gas LPG in the current fiscal, while fertiliser subsidy is projected to rise to ₹2.05 to 2.25 lakh crore.

Rating agency Icra said supply disruptions in the Strait of Hormuz — handling around 20 per cent of global oil and LNG trade — have tightened availability of fuels, fertilisers and chemicals, pushing up prices and increasing cost pressures across downstream industries. Crude prices before the West Asia crisis broke out two months back were around \$70-72 a barrel. "The stable pump prices for auto fuels amid elevated



crude oil prices are impacting the profitability of the oil marketing companies (OMCs)," said Prashant Vasishth, Senior Vice President and Co-Group Head, Icra.

"At crude prices of \$120-125 per barrel, marketing margins on petrol and diesel are estimated to be negative ₹14 a litre and ₹18 per litre, respectively," Icra estimates LPG under-recoveries could reach ₹80,000 crore in FY2027, if current trends persist, while the fertiliser subsidy burden is projected to rise to ₹2.05-2.25 lakh crore, above the budgeted ₹1.71 lakh crore.

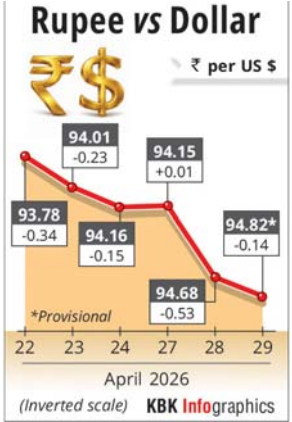
Rupee falls 14 paise to close near all-time low level against US dollar

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

The rupee depreciated 14 paise to close near its all-time low at 94.82 (provisional) against the US dollar on Wednesday, pressured by rising Brent crude oil prices, hovering around \$115 per barrel, and continued foreign capital outflows.

Forex traders said the elevated crude oil price is likely to sharply impact India's import costs, while the ongoing West Asia crisis and concerns over potential wider conflict are fuelling investor anxiety. Also, analysts said that investors were awaiting cues from the upcoming US Federal Reserve policy decision. Moreover, heavy foreign institutional investor (FII) selling so far this year further dented investor sentiment.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee



opened at 94.79 against the US dollar, then lost ground and touched an intraday low of 94.86 against the US dollar, and finally settled for the day at 94.82 (provisional), registering a fall of 14 paise over its previous close. On Tuesday, the rupee depreciated by 53 paise to close at 94.68 against the US dollar. The rupee's all-time

low closing level of 94.85 versus the US dollar was recorded on March 27 this year. The rupee continued to trade weakly, as sustained FII outflows and elevated crude prices near \$114 (Brent) kept pressure on the currency. Higher oil prices are significantly increasing India's import bill and inflation risks, limiting any meaningful recovery in the rupee.

"The trend remains weak, with the currency consistently facing selling pressure on rebounds, indicating a lack of strong support at higher levels. In the near term, 94.40 is likely to act as resistance, while 95.25 remains the next key support, with the rupee expected to stay volatile and driven by crude and capital flows," said Jateen Trivedi, VP Research Analyst — Commodity and Currency, LKP Securities.

Crude may impact India's GDP growth: EY

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India's GDP growth may slip to around 6 per cent and retail inflation could rise to RBI's upper tolerance band of 6 per cent in the current fiscal, if the Indian crude basket price averages \$120 a barrel, EY India said on Wednesday.

EY India Chief Policy Advisor DK Srivastava said, although room for policy interventions is limited, policymakers need to consider upward revision in the repo rate and accelerated diversification of sources of crude supply as the price of the Indian crude basket (ICB) may rise further if the West Asian crisis persists.

"If the ICB price averages \$120 per barrel in FY27, India's real GDP growth may slip to about 6 per cent and CPI inflation may increase to 6 per cent... To minimise the adverse impact on fiscal deficit,



increased energy prices should be passed on to the retailers to a relatively larger extent," Srivastava said.

The April 2026 release of the US Energy Information Administration EIA Short-Term Energy Outlook projects Brent crude oil prices to increase from an average of \$81 per barrel in Q1 2026 to a peak of \$115 per barrel in Q2 2026. Depending on how the crisis evolves,

crude prices may fall in the future.

The International Monetary Fund (IMF) has projected India's GDP growth at 6.5 per cent for FY27, while the Asian Development Bank (ADB) and the World Bank expect it to be 6.9 per cent and 6.6 per cent, respectively.

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI), in its monetary policy review earlier this month, projected GDP growth for

FY27 at 6.9 per cent compared to 7.6 per cent estimated in FY26. The RBI also projected inflation to average 4.6 per cent for FY27.

In the EY Economy Watch report, Srivastava said current indications suggest that the West Asian crisis may last well beyond expectations of a short-lived conflict. Even after it is resolved, considerable time would be required for the global crude supply situation to normalise.

"As such, India's growth may be lower than 6.5 per cent and inflation somewhat higher than RBI's baseline projections," he said, adding that there is a likelihood of the ICB price exceeding \$95 per barrel on average in FY27.

"Even so, India's growth in FY27 is expected to be more than double that of global growth under an adverse scenario," Srivastava said.

Healthy rise in exports in April so far: Goyal



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The country's exports have shown a healthy increase during the first-three weeks of April so far despite the ongoing West Asia crisis, Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal said on Wednesday. He also said that free trade agreements finalised by India would give a huge boost to the domestic industry.

"There is an increase in exports during the first three weeks of April as compared to the same period of last April. Despite the war in West Asia, there is tremendous enthusiasm among domestic exporters," Goyal told reporters here.

On exports to West Asia, he said the consignments are going through different routes because the Strait of Hormuz is still a challenge.

When asked about the progress in negotiations for a trade pact with the US, the minister said, "We had very good discussions, I think about a week ago. Our team is back, and we continue to engage."

He added that the Government has finalised a number of trade pacts with countries, including UAE, UK, EU, four European nation bloc EFTA (European Free Trade Association), Australia, Mauritius, and Oman. "Another 12 are on the anvil," he said. India is negotiating a trade agreement with Israel, Gulf Cooperation Council, and Canada.

ATMA seeks customs duty relief on key raw materials to tide over West Asia war impact

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Automotive Tyre Manufacturers Association on Wednesday said it has asked the Government to extend policy support, including customs duty relief on critical raw materials, to mitigate supply chain uncertainties arising from the ongoing West Asia crisis.



The tyre manufacturers' body has made a representation to the Government seeking temporary customs duty exemption on key inputs, including polyester/nylon tyre cord fabric, bead wire, steel tyre cord, carbon black, processing oils, and petrochemical-based chemicals, the Automotive Tyre Manufacturers Association (ATMA) said in a statement. "ATMA appreciated the recent decision to grant temporary customs duty exemption on select raw

materials such as synthetic rubber and certain resins until June 30, 2026," it said. The Government's action was a timely and supportive step for the industry, ATMA added.

However, several other key inputs — including polyester/nylon tyre cord fabric, bead wire, steel tyre cord, carbon black, processing oils and petrochemical-based chemicals — continue to attract significant import duties despite ongoing price volatility and supply constraints, it said.

"We appreciate the Government's timely support. However, given continued global uncertainties, extending duty relief to other critical raw materials is essential to maintain production stability and cost competitiveness," ATMA Chairman Arun Mammen said. Stating that the crude-linked inputs account for nearly 60-70 per cent of total raw material costs in tyre manufacturing, ATMA said with crude prices remaining volatile and key shipping routes such as the Strait of Hormuz and the Suez Canal under stress, the industry is facing rising input costs, shipment delays and higher freight and insurance charges.

ATMA said it also raised concerns regarding supply constraints of bead wire, a critical component for tyre safety, with domestic manufacturers facing pressure due to shortages of industrial gas and LPG.

Global auto industry facing demanding environment: OICA President

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The global automotive industry is facing a demanding environment due to factors such as uncertainty linked to trade tensions, supply chains and energy prices, according to International Organisation of Motor Vehicle Manufacturers (OICA) President Shailesh Chandra.

Speaking at the launch of OICA's Global Automobile Industry's annual sales data at the sidelines of the Beijing Motor Show, he said technological change, geopolitical pressures and diverging public policies are reshaping the global automotive industry. Although there is growth



in the automotive industry globally, it is distributed with some regions witnessing growth while others declined, Chandra, who is also the President of Society of Indian Automobile Manufacturers (SIAM) and Managing Director & CEO, Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles Ltd, said. In 2025, global automobile production of passenger vehicles,

trucks and buses rose to 9.64 crore units from 9.27 crore units in 2024, an increase of 3.9 per cent, he said.

On the other hand, global vehicle sales increased to 9.98 crore units in 2025 from 9.53 crore units in 2024, posting a growth of 4.7 per cent, Chandra said.

"The industry remains resilient, but the environment has become far more demanding. Manufacturers are managing slower growth in some markets, fiercer competition in others, and continued uncertainty linked to trade tensions, supply chains, affordability, energy prices and the pace of electrification," Chandra said.

Nearly one-third of record peak demand of 256 GW met through renewable energy: Joshi

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Union Minister Pralhad Joshi on Wednesday said that nearly one-third of the record peak demand of over 256 GW earlier this month was met through renewable energy like solar, wind and hydro.

The peak power demand touched a record high of 256.11 GW on Saturday, April 25, 2026, according to Power Ministry data.

Speaking at the Resilient Futures Summit organised by Economist Enterprise, Joshi, the new and renewable energy minister, said that one-third of the peak power generation on 25th April was successfully met through renewable energy.

That itself showcases that India is capable of generating and India is capable of handling peak power demand through renewable energy, he pointed out.

The minister highlighted that India is investing in grid modernisation, digitisation, and also using AI and digital twins.

"I think in the coming days...the generation capac-



ity will also increase," he said. The minister also said that the Government is making efforts to translate installed capacity into actual generation, and consequently transmission to boost the share of renewable energy in the power basket.

The Ministry of Power on Tuesday said, "India has successfully met its all-time highest peak electricity demand of 256.1 GW on 25th April 2026 at 15:38 hrs without any shortage, while simultaneously maintaining electricity exports to neighbouring countries".

At the time of peak demand, the requirement was met through a diverse portfolio of generation sources, including thermal,

hydro, nuclear, and renewable energy, ensuring reliability and grid stability. Renewable energy, particularly solar, made a significant contribution, complemented by hydro and other flexible resources during peak conditions, the ministry had said.

According to the ministry, solar contributed 21.5 per cent of power generation to meet the peak of 256.1 GW on April 25.

The hydro power contribution was 4.4 per cent, and wind energy added 1.9 per cent. Nuclear power and gas contributed 2.4 per cent and 2 per cent, respectively.

The contribution of thermal power was 66.9 per cent, it stated.

Delhi witnesses surge in solar rooftop installations

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The number of rooftop solar installations is surging in the national capital, with the power discoms energising over 23,000 connections in residential, commercial, industrial and other categories.

BSES discoms — BRPL and BYPL — have together energised more than 13,600 rooftop connections with a total load of around 260 MWp (megawatt peak load). In 2025-26 alone, more than 4,600 rooftop connections, including over 26 under the PM Surya Ghar scheme, were energised by the discom, said a BSES spokesperson. Tata Power Delhi Distribution Limited (TPDDL), which



covers around 28 per cent of the total distribution area in the city, has so far registered over 18,000 households under its flagship project 'Suryansh' and energised a record 4,011 connections in the previous

year, which is the highest annual addition so far, said a company statement.

Discom officials said transformative Government schemes and growing interest are leading to the surge in rooftop solar adoption in Delhi.

The consumers can avail a total subsidy of up to ₹1.08 lakh, including ₹78,000 from the Centre and ₹30,000 from the Delhi Government, and also earn generation-based incentives under the existing policies.

The BSES spokesperson said that for a typical household, a 5 KW rooftop system can potentially deliver savings of ₹3,500 or more per month, depending on consumption levels and tariff slab.

The surplus solar power is sold to the discoms at Delhi Electricity Regulatory Commission (DERC) determined rates.

"A major catalyst behind the sharp rise in solar rooftops has been the central Government's PM Surya Ghar: Muft Bijli Yojana, which, along with Delhi Solar Policy, has significantly improved affordability for residential consumers," he said.

Discom data showed that the residential category leads in the number of rooftop solar connections. The BSES discoms have a total of 9,888 residential installations, followed by commercial establishments (2,184), educational institutions (1,009), others (342) and industrial consumers (207).

India, Kenya discuss possibility of trade settlement in local currencies

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India and Kenya have discussed the possibility of settling trade transactions in local currencies to further promote two-way commerce, an official statement said on Wednesday.

Discussions on digital public infrastructure covered collaboration on UPI-like payment systems, Bharat Connect and digital platforms to enhance financial inclusion, which also helps officials of the two nations.

These issues were discussed in the India-Kenya Joint Trade

Committee meeting on April 27-28. It was co-chaired by Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal and Principal Secretary, State Department for Trade, Kenya, Regina Akotah Ombam, in Nairobi.

"Both sides acknowledged the potential for promoting trade settlement in local currencies. The possibility of adopting a Local Currency Settlement (LCS) mechanism was also discussed," the Commerce Ministry said.

It was noted that Kenyan banks have opened Special Rupee Vostro Accounts (SRVAs) with Indian banks,



and greater utilisation of this framework could facilitate smoother bilateral transactions.

The two countries have discussed ways to enhance trade diversification, address market access issues and

leverage complementarities in sectors, such as engineering goods, pharmaceuticals, agriculture and electronics.

It said that an MoU was also signed between the Central Board of Indirect Taxes and Customs (CBIC) and the Kenya Revenue Authority (KRA) for the exchange of pre-arrival customs information, with emphasis on streamlining customs procedures and improving ease of doing business.

The total bilateral trade stood at \$4.31 billion in 2025-26, reflecting an increase of 24.91 per cent from \$3.45 billion in 2024-25.

FROM THE WORLD

Currency hits record low

Iran

warms Iran as energy prices hit economies

Iran's national rial currency hit a record low Wednesday of 1.8 million to \$1 as a shaky ceasefire with the US and Israel still holds. The rial had remained stable for weeks during the war, which began February 28, in part because there was little trading or imports coming into the country. The rial began to slide two days ago, hitting the record low on Wednesday. Experts warn the fall of the rial is likely to further fuel inflation in a country where many imported goods, from food and medicine to electronics and raw materials, are affected by the dollar rate. The war is now in a ceasefire, but a US blockade has continued to increase pressure on Iran's already-battered economy, cutting into a key source of Government revenue and hard currency by stopping or intercepting oil shipments.

CHINA

Beijing clamps down on drones

Beijing is banning all drones within city limits starting May 1. The Chinese capital's city government passed a series of ordinances in late March banning drone sales and flights, although users have long been blocked from flying drones within the city. A search on Taobao, one of China's top online shopping platforms, showed that users with a Beijing delivery address could not check out with a drone in their cart. An employee at a Beijing store of consumer electronics brand DJI told state-backed media outlet Jieman that they have been told to get rid of any drones in stock by Thursday.

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Two Jews stabbed in London; police declare it a terrorist attack

ADITI KHANNA ■ London

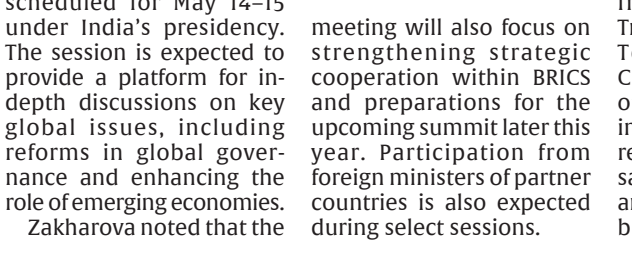
London police say the stabbing of two Jewish men has been declared a terrorist incident. Metropolitan Police say they are investigating whether Wednesday's attack specifically targeted the Jewish community. The force says the attack in the Golders Green area left two men, aged 34 and 76, hospitalized with knife wounds. A 45-year-old man has been arrested on suspicion of attempted murder. British Prime Minister Keir Starmer on Wednesday led condemnations of an antisemitic attack in north-west London, which involved two men being stabbed after a knife man was seen running down a street near a synagogue. The Metropolitan Police said Counter-Terror officers are leading an investigation after a 45-year-old male suspect was Tasered and arrested. Jewish volunteer patrol group Shomrim said the man was seen running along Golders



UN forces operating in southern Lebanon

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

Russian Foreign Minister Sergei Lavrov is set to visit New Delhi next month to participate in the BRICS Foreign Ministers' Meeting, the Russian Foreign Ministry announced on Wednesday. Speaking at a media briefing in Moscow, Foreign Ministry spokesperson Maria Zakharova said that Lavrov will attend the meeting scheduled for May 14-15 under India's presidency. The session is expected to provide a platform for in-depth discussions on key global issues, including reforms in global governance and enhancing the role of emerging economies. Zakharova noted that the



Sergei Lavrov

During his visit, Lavrov will hold bilateral talks with India's External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar. The discussions will cover a wide range of issues, including bilateral relations, high-level engagements, and coordination on upcoming diplomatic interactions. Special emphasis will be placed on preparations for meetings of the Inter Governmental Russian-Indian Commission on Trade, Economic, Scientific, Technical and Cultural Cooperation, alongside other matters of mutual interest. The visit follows a recent telephonic conversation between Jaishankar and Lavrov, during which both leaders exchanged

Rafael Grossi said in an interview on Tuesday that the International Atomic Energy Agency has satellite images showing the effects of the latest US-Israeli airstrikes against Iran and that "we continue to get information". IAEA inspections ended at Isfahan when Israel last June launched a 12-day war that saw the United States bomb three Iranian nuclear sites. The UN nuclear watchdog believes a large percentage of Iran's highly enriched uranium "was stored there in June 2025 when the 12-day war broke out, and it has been there ever since," Grossi said.

Lebanese army soldier killed in Israeli strike

A Lebanese army soldier was killed Wednesday along with his brother in an Israeli strike that targeted the

motorcycle on which they were travelling from the soldier's work post to his home in the village of al-Souaneh, the army said in a statement. The Lebanese army has stood on the sidelines during the latest Israel-Hezbollah war, which began on March 2 when the militant group launched a salvo of missiles into Israel, two days after the US and Israel launched their attacks on Iran. A total of 20 Lebanese army soldiers have been killed by Israeli strikes since March 2, most of them while en route to or from their duty stations, the army said. Altogether, more than 2,500 people have been killed in Lebanon during the war and during a shaky ceasefire implemented earlier this month that has reduced but not halted the fighting.

Lebanon detains former Palestinian envoy at Beirut Airport

Lebanese authorities detained the former Palestinian ambassador to Lebanon on corruption charges shortly after he arrived in the country, officials said Wednesday. The officials said Ashraf Dabbour was arrested upon arrival at Beirut's Rafik Hariri International Airport late Tuesday. The two judicial and two security officials spoke on condition of anonymity because they were not authorised to speak to the media. Palestinian President Mahmoud Abbas relieved Dabbour of his post as Palestinian ambassador to Lebanon last year after the Palestinian Authority accused him of corruption. The Lebanese officials said authorities detained Dabbour in Beirut based on a Red Notice issued by the Interpol late last year. Dabbour was reportedly involved in selling property in Lebanon that was owned by the Palestinian Liberation Organisation that was based in the country until Israel's 1982 invasion of Lebanon.



Ashraf Dabbour

उपग्रह राज्य औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण

उपग्रह राज्य औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण

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उपग्रह राज्य औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण

PUBLIC NOTICE

My Clientess Smt. Sunita, W/o Late Sh. Jai Bhagwan, R/o H. No. 106, Chaupal Road, Issapur Village, South West Delhi-110073, hereby declare that his son Amit (S/o Late Sh. Jai Bhagwan) and his wife Pooja Solanki, due to their misconduct, are disowned and debarred from all movable and immovable properties and relations. They shall have no right or claim whatsoever. Any person dealing with them shall do so at his/her own risk.

Tanya Kapoor (Advocate) Chamber D-620, Karkardooma Courts, Delhi

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given that 1st Extra ordinary General Meeting of members of Rotographics (India) Limited will be held on Friday, 22nd May, 2026 at 12:00 P.M. through video conferencing (VCI) other audio visual means (OAVM).

Rotographics (INDIA) LIMITED

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SENATE REJECTS ATTEMPT TO END TRUMP'S BLOCKADE OF CUBA

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PUBLIC NOTICE

Known to all that my client Mr. Satish Kumar owner of Plot No. 34, Area 27 Sq. Yds., Kharsa No. 16/12, Ram Chander Enclave, Maharani Enclave, Uttam Nagar, New Delhi-110059, and My Client Purchased aforesaid property from Mr. Brij Kishor Gupta & Mr. Mukesh Kumar vide Notarized GPA, ATS and Will dated 03.03.2026, now My Client wants to sell aforesaid property. And it is informed that any deal with said documents by any person except my said client and said institution regarding said property, shall be deemed as null and void. If any person having any claim, right in said property then he may contact and handover the same and apprise his claim to undersigned within 15 days of this publication.

AD REM LEGAL SOLUTION

Ch. No. 760 - Dwarka Court Sector-10, Dwarka, New Delhi-75 Mobile :- 9899013918

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given to the General Public on behalf of my client (SMFG India Credit Co. Ltd.) that Mr. Laxman Singh Gill s/o Late Balram Gill is claiming to be the owner of Property bearing No. 1083, measuring 162 sq. yds., out of Khata No. 4 & 3, situated in extended abadi of Lal Dora Village-Madipur, Dr. Ambedkar Nagar, New Delhi vide a Regd. Relinquishment Deed dt. 08.04.2019 executed by Mrs. Satyawati & Mr. Sagar wife & son of Late Harpal, duly regd. with Document No. 2740 (SRO-V-A, Hazr Khos, Delhi). All persons are hereby informed that above owner wants to mortgage said property with SMFG India Credit Co. Ltd. against the said claim (SMFG India Credit Co. Ltd.) against the said property, if anybody has any objection/s on the ownership of above owners over the said property, its mortgage/litigation, and any other objections, kindly inform the undersigned in writing on the below mentioned address within 87 days of the present.

AD REM LEGAL SOLUTION

Ch. No. 760 - Dwarka Court Sector-10, Dwarka, New Delhi-75 Mobile :- 9899013918

PUBLIC NOTICE

Known to all that my client Dhamam Pal Goyal owner of Third floor, (Rear RH5), with roof, Plot no. 38 & 50, area 200 sq mtrs., Kharsa No. 42/1 & 38/21/2 (42/1 & 38/21), Dwarka Vihar, Kakrola Road, New Delhi, and My Client Purchased aforesaid property from Shikha Aggarwal vide Notarized GPA, ATS and Will dated 15.04.2023, now My Client wants to sell aforesaid property. And it is informed that any deal with said documents by any person except my said client and said institution regarding said property, shall be deemed as null and void. If any person having any claim, right in said property then he may contact and handover the same and apprise his claim to undersigned within 15 days of this publication.

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PUBLIC NOTICE

This is to inform the general public that Mrs. Sampati Devi was owner of House No. 102/25, adjoining 60 sq. yards, situated at Abadi of Lal Dora, Tehsil Ballabhgarh, District Faridabad, Haryana through Transference Deed of Unde dtd.05.02.1960 as doc no. 97 executed by Mr. Mukesh Inder in favour of Mrs. Sampati Devi in respect of said property. Thereafter, Regd. Will dated 03.03.2026 executed by Mrs. Sampati Devi in favour of Mr. Khemchand Modi in respect of said property. Unfortunately, Mrs. Sampati Devi, Khemchand Modi and Mr. Ravinder Kumar Modi had expired. Thereafter, Release Deed dated 22.08.2014 as doc. no. 3205 executed by Mrs. Anita, Mrs. Deepa, Mr. Nareish Modi, Mrs. Kamlesh, Mrs. Madhu & Mrs. Rama in favour of Mr. Sachin Modi and Mr. Gagan Modi and Mr. Gagan Modi intended to transfer the ownership of above said Property by Regd. Will dated 03.03.2026 executed by Mrs. Anita, Mrs. Deepa, Mr. Nareish Modi, Mrs. Kamlesh, Mrs. Madhu & Mrs. Rama in favour of Mr. Sachin Modi and Mr. Gagan Modi and Mr. Gagan Modi intended to transfer the ownership of above said Property by Regd. Will dated 03.03.2026 executed by Mrs. Anita, Mrs. Deepa, Mr. Nareish Modi, Mrs. Kamlesh, Mrs. Madhu & Mrs. Rama in favour of Mr. Sachin Modi and Mr. Gagan Modi and Mr. Gagan Modi intended to transfer the ownership of above said Property by Regd. Will dated 03.03.2026 executed by Mrs. Anita, Mrs. Deepa, Mr. Nareish Modi, Mrs. Kamlesh, Mrs. Madhu & Mrs. Rama in favour of Mr. Sachin Modi and Mr. Gagan Modi and Mr. Gagan Modi intended to transfer the ownership of above said Property by Regd. Will dated 03.03.2026 executed by Mrs. Anita, Mrs. Deepa, Mr. Nareish Modi, Mrs. Kamlesh, Mrs. Madhu & Mrs. Rama in favour of Mr. Sachin Modi and Mr. Gagan Modi and Mr. Gagan Modi intended to transfer the ownership of above said Property by Regd. 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Kyiv hits Russian oil facility in Perm region

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Kyiv

Another oil facility deep inside Russia was reportedly on fire on Wednesday following what Ukraine's president claimed was his country's latest long-range drone attack.

The facility is in the Perm region of Russia, located in the Ural mountains more than 1,500 kilometres (900 miles) from Ukraine, Russian media said, with some unconfirmed reports saying it was a pumping station and storage complex.

Perm Governor Dmitry Makhonin said only that a drone hit an unspecified industrial facility, sparking a fire. Russian officials have not been forthcoming about



Workers putting out a fire of a residential building destroyed by a Russian drone strike in Ukraine

Ukrainian claims that Kyiv is carrying out more long-range attacks and that its domestically developed drones are increasingly accurate.

Advanced drone technology

has become a defining feature of the battle as Russia's bigger army presses its more than four-year invasion of its neighbour.

Ukraine's response has

included a drive to develop new drones for attack and defence. Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy on Wednesday posted a video on the Telegram messaging

app showing a large plume of black smoke rising into the sky in countryside near a built-up area.

Without specifying it was the reported Perm attack or what was hit, Zelenskyy said Ukraine was expanding the range of its long-distance strikes, describing them as a new phase in efforts to limit Russia's ability to wage war by denying it crucial oil revenue.

It was not possible to independently verify the video.

Zelenskyy thanked the Security Service of Ukraine for the precision of its strikes.

"The straight-line distance is more than 1,500 kilometers. We will continue to increase these ranges," he said. The attack came a day

after Ukraine struck the Tuapse oil refinery and terminal on the Black Sea for the third time in less than two weeks, prompting the evacuation of local people and threatening what Russian President Vladimir Putin said could be "serious environmental consequences".

Ukraine has escalated its long-distance strike campaign against Russian oil facilities in an effort to stop Moscow gaining a financial windfall from a US waiver on sanctions amid global supply restrictions caused by the Iran war, according to the Institute for the Study of War, a Washington-based think tank. Kyiv is exploiting the vulnerabilities of Russia's large land mass, it said.

Colombians split on fate of Pablo Escobar's hippos



ASTRID SUAREZ ■ Puerto Triunfo (Colombia)

Along the Magdalena River, one of Colombia's primary arteries, fishermen move with wary precision. From the silty, tea-coloured current, hippopotamuses can surface without warning, closing the distance to a vessel in a single heartbeat.

"These hippos are a true nightmare," said fisherman Wilinton Sanchez about the semi-aquatic animals capable of charging at speeds of up to 8 kilometers (5 miles) per hour in water and 30 kilometers (18 miles) on land.

"We were out Saturday when one lunged ... reared up and swung its jaws wide. If it ever gets hold of you, it'll tear you to pieces." The animals also draw fascination.

Several afternoons a week, boats filled with Colombian and foreign tourists arrive to scan the shoreline waiting for signs in the murky water.

Even these "hippo-watching" outings can occasionally end in screams as the animals close the distance with terrifying speed, but they also bring needed business to the community.

The hippos, an invasive species in Colombia, are part of a population of 200 that continues to reproduce unchecked. They are the offspring of animals illegally brought to the country in the 1980s by the late drug kingpin Pablo Escobar for his private zoo at Hacienda Napoles - a sprawling valley estate that featured a private airstrip and served as his secluded fortress.

Sri Lanka resumes Chemmani mass grave site excavation



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Colombo

A Sri Lankan court has ordered the recommencement of excavation work on a mass grave in Chemmani, on the outskirts of Jaffna, which first came into focus during the LTTE conflict in the 1990s, seven months after it was halted.

The excavation work in Chemmani in the Northern Province came to a halt in September last year due to the pending new allocation of funds by the Ministry of Justice.

The Jaffna magistrate's court was told on Tuesday that LKR 2.1 million allocation has been made available so that work can be resumed.

The court granted permission for diplomatic representatives from the EU, France, Germany, Italy and Romania to be present for observations at the excavation site.

When the second stage of work was halted after 45 days, 240 skeletal remains had been excavated.

Russia to hold Victory Day parade without military equipment

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Moscow

Russia's traditional parade marking the 81st anniversary of the defeat of Nazi Germany in World War II will take place without military equipment, the Russian Defense Ministry said in a statement late Tuesday.

It will be the first time since Moscow launched its full-scale invasion of Ukraine in 2022 that no military equipment will rumble through Moscow's Red Square on May 9, the day Russia celebrates its most important secular holiday and showcases its military might.

The ministry statement cited the "current operational situation" as a reason for excluding a mil-

itary equipment convoy, as well as cadets, from the parade. The statement didn't elaborate.

The parade will feature "servicemen from higher military educational institutions of all kinds and certain service branches of the Russian Armed Forces" and a traditional military aircraft flyover, the ministry said. World War II is a rare event in the nation's divisive history under Communist rule that is revered by all political groups, and the Kremlin has used that sentiment to encourage national pride and underline Russia's position as a global power.

The Soviet Union lost 27 million people in what it



calls the Great Patriotic War in 1941-45, an enormous sacrifice that left a deep scar in the national psyche.

President Vladimir Putin, who has ruled Russia for over 25 years, has turned Victory Day into a key pillar of his tenure and has tried to

use it to justify the war in Ukraine. Last year's parade was the largest since Russia sent troops into Ukraine, and drew the most global leaders to Moscow in a decade, including high-profile guests like Chinese President Xi Jinping,

Brazilian President Luiz Inacio Lula da Silva and Slovakia's Prime Minister Robert Fico.

It featured over 11,500 troops and more than 180 military vehicles, including tanks, armoured infantry vehicles and artillery used on the battlefield in Ukraine, as well as huge Yars nuclear-tipped intercontinental ballistic missiles launchers and drones carried on military trucks. Fighter jets flew over Red Square, too.

Putin had declared a unilateral 72-hour ceasefire starting May 7, and the authorities blocked cellphone internet in Moscow for several days in an effort to avert Ukrainian drone attacks.

Terrorist killed in Pakistan

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Peshawar

Pakistani security forces killed a terrorist early on Wednesday in the northwestern Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province, repelling an attack on a police post, local media reported.

Heavily armed terrorists attacked the Mazanga police post in Bannu district, police officials said.

One terrorist was killed and several others injured in the intense exchange of fire between the two sides, the Dawn newspaper reported.

The injured attackers were taken away by their accomplices under the cover of darkness, it added.

Following the incident, police cordoned off the area



and initiated a search operation. A constable, who sustained minor injuries in the attack, was shifted to a hospital where he was reported to be out of danger.

Search suspended for missing mariners in US

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Saipan (US)

The search has been suspended for five missing crew members of a cargo ship that overturned near the Northern Mariana Islands during a typhoon, authorities said on Wednesday.

Six people were aboard the 145-foot ship, called the Mariana. Divers on April 21 recovered one crew member's body from the overturned ship.

"We are deeply saddened to announce that despite widespread efforts, we have made the difficult decision to suspend our search for the missing crew members of the Mariana," Cmdr. Preston Hieb of the US Coast Guard Oceania District said in a video posted on X. "We offer our heartfelt condolences to the families of the Mariana crew, as well as the entire Saipan community." The search was stopped two weeks after the crew notified the Coast Guard that the ship had lost its starboard engines and



needed assistance as Super Typhoon Sinlaku battered the Pacific island chain. The Coast Guard lost contact with the vessel the next day.

Heavy wind hindered initial search efforts, but the overturned ship was eventually spotted on April 18 about 64 kilometers northeast of Pagan, one of the islands that make up the Northern Marianas, which is a US territory.

Acid attack against activist: Indonesian soldiers stand trial

ANDI JATMIKO/ NINIEK KARMINI ■ Jakarta

A trial opened Wednesday for four Indonesian service members accused of carrying out an acid attack on a prominent human rights activist, in a case that has reignited concerns about military impunity.

Three Indonesian navy marines and one air force officer, all assigned to military intelligence, are charged with serious premeditated assault in the March attack on Andrie Yunus, a human rights lawyer and senior activist with the Commission for the Disappeared and Victims of



Violence, known as KontraS. Those on trial in a military court in Jakarta are Sgt Edi Sudarko; First Lt Budhi Hariyanto Widhi Cahyono; Capt. Nandala Dwi Prasetya; and Air Force First Lt Sami Lakka. The charges carry a sentence of up to 12 years in prison if convicted. Prosecutors allege the four men acted together but

described the motive as personal. They said the defendants attacked Yunus with acid "to teach him a lesson and deter him from making disparaging remarks about the TNI."

"The actions of the defendants who threw chemical liquid on Andrie Yunus, resulting in the loss of sight in his right eye and severe burns with no hope of complete recovery, were inappropriate actions for members of the TNI," Iswandi told the court.

Human rights groups criticized both the personal-motive narrative and the decision to try the case in a military court instead of a civilian one. (AP)

Untargeted energy aid risks billions, warns EU chief

LORNE COOK ■ Brussels

European Union countries must funnel their energy aid chiefly to vulnerable households and industries or risk wasting billions of euros as the Iran war hits oil and gas prices, European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen warned on Wednesday.

The US-Israel war, combined with retaliation from Iran such as choking the Strait of Hormuz, is costing the EU almost 500 million euros (\$600 million) a day, raising prices at the pumps and fears of a jet fuel shortage within weeks.

Von der Leyen said the world's biggest trading bloc must draw on the lessons of the 2022 fuel crisis - when Russia used its energy might



against European countries to undermine their support for Ukraine - to avoid further hurting their economies.

More than 350 billion euros "were spent on untargeted measures and this had a huge impact on member

states finances," she told EU lawmakers in Strasbourg, France. "So let us not make the same mistake again, and let's focus our support where it matters most."

Just as Europe broke its energy dependency on

Russia, the bloc must now end its reliance on supplies from the outside world, by making better use of renewable sources like wind and solar, as well as nuclear power, von der Leyen said.

"Our over dependency on imported fossil fuels makes us vulnerable," she said.

Since the war started in 2022, Russian gas imports into the 27 nations have fallen from 45 per cent to 12 per cent last year. Coal imports were banned by sanctions, and oil imports shrank from 27 per cent in 2022 to 2 per cent, with only Hungary and Slovakia continuing to buy from Russia. Von der Leyen said the impact of the Iran war "may echo for months or even years to come" and that the path to energy independence

lies in "homegrown, affordable, clean energy supply from renewables to nuclear."

She urged EU countries to use more electricity generated by renewable sources and nuclear sources to power transport and planes, heat homes, and undercut the dependency on fossil fuels in industry. Electricity makes up less than a quarter of the bloc's energy consumption.

EU Energy Commissioner Dan Jorgensen warned last week that the Iran war has not just produced "a short-term, small increase in prices. This is a crisis that is probably as serious as the 1973 and the 2022 crises combined."

He said Europe has been forced onto the defensive and has little control over events. (AP)

Just give us a ring: King Charles III's gifts to Donald Trump strike a friendly chord

ADITI KHANNA ■ London

The original bell from a UK-made Second World War submarine named HMS Trump was the centrepiece of a set of gifts presented by King Charles III to US President Donald Trump during the State Visit this week.

The "personal gift" was unveiled at the White House state dinner on Tuesday as the 77-year-old monarch delivered his address, striking a friendly and light-hearted note to his formal speech.

Trump looked visibly impressed by the gift and praised "fantastic" Charles at the white-tie event.

"Today, our partnerships in NATO (North Atlantic Treaty Organisation) and AUKUS (Australia-UK-US alliance) deepen our technological and military



President Donald Trump, Melania Trump greeting Britain's King Charles III and Queen Camilla at the South Portico of the White House in Washington.

cooperation and ensure that, together, we can meet the challenges of an increasingly complex and contested world," the king said in his address. "And speaking of

submarine alliances, there was one particular AUKUS predecessor, launched from a UK shipyard in 1944, that served for the majority of her life attached to the 4th

Submarine Squadron in Australia, playing a critical role during the war in the Pacific. Her name? HMS Trump. "So tonight, Mr President, I am delighted to present to you - as a personal gift - the original bell which hung on the Conning Tower of your valiant namesake. May it stand as a testimony to our nations' shared history and shining future. And should you ever need to get hold of us, well, just give us a ring," he said, evoking laughter and applause.

The more public gift presentation followed an earlier closed-door exchange, when Buckingham Palace said the British monarch presented the American president with a framed facsimile of the 1879 design plans for the iconic desk in the Oval Office at White House - the orig-

inals of which are held by the National Maritime Museum in Greenwich, London.

"These drawings show the front elevation, top and projection of the President's Desk, currently located in the Oval Office of the White House," the palace stated. According to the accompanying historic details released in London, the "Resolute Desk" was created from the timbers of the British exploration ship HMS Resolute.

The US Government recovered and refitted the ship before sending it back to England where it was presented to Queen Victoria on December 17, 1856, as a "gesture of goodwill and friendship between the United States and the United Kingdom". HMS Resolute went on to serve in the Royal Navy until 1879, when it was

decommissioned. Three desks were then made from the ship's timber by master carpenter William Evenden, at the Royal Navy Dockyard in Chatham, Kent.

On November 23, 1880, the finished Resolute Desk was presented to President Rutherford B. Hayes by Queen Victoria.

As is customary, Queen Camilla also presented a brooch by a British designer as her royal gift to First Lady Melania Trump.

"British jewellery designer Fiona Rae has been designing and making jewellery for over 34 years. After graduating from Central Saint Martins, Fiona, a member of the British Society of Enamellers, received advice and a loan from the Prince's Trust (now The King's Trust) and is today one of the UK's few enamel specialists,"

Buckingham Palace stated, with reference to the brooch. Granted the Royal Warrant by the king in 2024, Rae's work focusses on a fusion of traditional craft skills alongside the latest developments in technology and computer-aided design. The palace also revealed details of the gifts received by the senior royals from the American president and first lady in exchange.

While Trump presented Charles with a custom facsimile of a letter written from John Adams to John Jay in 1785, Melania gifted Camilla six Tiffany's English King Sterling Silver Teaspoons and White House Honey. On June 2, 1785, in a letter from John to John Jay, Adams describes His Majesty King George III receiving Adams as the first US Ambassador to Great Britain at St. James' Palace in London. (PTI)

PROSPECT

DIG, Assam Rifles interact with United Naga Council delegation in Manipur



Assam Rifles held an interaction with a delegation of the United Naga Council (UNC) lead by it's President NG Lorho, at Jawalamukhi Garrison, Liarouching in Senapati district of Manipur on April 28. The interaction was focused on the prevailing security situation in the region amid ongoing tensions in the Ukhrul area. Both sides exchanged views on issues concerning peace, stability and the well-being of local communities. Assam Rifles reiterated its commitment to maintaining peace and security, ensuring safety of all communities and fostering an environment conducive to dialogue and harmony. The interaction concluded on a positive note with a shared resolve to promote mutual understanding, prevent escalation of tensions and work towards lasting peace and normalcy in the region.

First All India Moot Court Competition at Dr Akhilesh Das Gupta Law School concludes

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The First All India Moot Court Competition at Dr Akhilesh Das Gupta Law School concluded successfully on April 29 with a prestigious valedictory ceremony. The two-day event stood as an excellent example of intense legal deliberation and advocacy skills. The Chief Guest for the valedictory ceremony was Dr T R Naval, Additional District & Sessions Judge (Retd.). He was welcomed by Dr Vijay Dheer, Director (Coordination), who presented him with a shawl. Director Prof.(Dr) Niranjan Bhattacharya honored the Chief Guest with a sapling and a memento. Other dignitaries present included Prof. Dr Jogi Ram Sharma (Principal), Pankhuri Aggarwal (Assistant Director - HR), faculty members, and staff. In his inspiring address, Dr

T R Naval emphasised that moot court competitions are a powerful platform for shaping future advocates. Highlighting the growing influence of technology and artificial intelligence-particularly deepfake technology-he stressed the need for the law to evolve continuously. He encouraged students to develop discipline, knowledge, research aptitude, and logical reasoning, while remaining dedicated to serving society. During the ceremony, the results of the competition were announced. The winning team was TC-34 from Law Centre-I, Faculty of Law, University of Delhi (Saloni Rawal, Abhyansh Dixit, and Arya Singh). They were awarded a trophy, certificates, and a cash prize of ₹25,000. The Runner-Up team, TC-40 from IILM University, Greater Noida (Lavi Rajput, Devesh Verma, and Gummati Harshini),

Govt proposes amendments to motor rules for ethanol use

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The Ministry of Road Transport and Highways has proposed amendments to vehicle emission rules to widen the scope for higher ethanol blends and alternative fuels, paving the way for flex-fuel and pure biofuel vehicles across all vehicle categories. The draft changes to the Central Motor Vehicles Rules, 1989 aim to provide for wider use of fuels, such as E85 (a blend of 85 per cent ethanol with petrol) and E100 (which would allow vehicles to run on nearly pure ethanol), as well as B100 biodiesel and hydrogen-CNG combinations. India has already achieved 20 per cent blending of ethanol (produced from biomass like sugarcane, corn or rice) with petrol to create a cleaner-burning fuel, reducing reliance on imported crude oil and cutting carbon emissions. In an April 27 gazette notification, the ministry said the changes would be taken up after a 30-day public consultation period, during which stakehold-



ers can submit objections or suggestions. Among key proposals, the draft raises the vehicle weight limit from 3,000 kg to 3,500 kg, bringing regulation in sync with global standards for light commercial vehicles. This means more vans, pickups, and small trucks will now fall under the same emission testing rules. It recognises fuels with higher blends of renewable biofuels - E20 (20 per cent ethanol blended petrol), E85 (85 per cent ethanol), E100 (100 per cent ethanol) and B100 (100 per cent biodiesel).

Lok Sabha Speaker calls for collective action for sustainable conservation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Nainital

Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla on Wednesday called for a coordinated and proactive approach involving all stakeholders-government institutions, Panchayati Raj Institutions, Urban Local Bodies, Van Panchayats, and citizens-to ensure sustainable development and ecological balance. He emphasised that empowering local communities and respecting traditional knowledge systems are essential for long-term environmental sustainability and national progress. Addressing representatives of Van Panchayats, elected members of the three-tier Panchayati Raj system, and Urban Local Bodies at Dr Raghunandan Singh Tolia Administrative Academy, Nainital, Birla noted that Uttarakhand's Van Panchayats have emerged as



Lok Sabha Speaker addressing representatives of Van Panchayats, Panchayati Raj Institutions and Urban local bodies in Nainital, Uttarakhand

a successful model of community-based forest management. He said that these institutions are contributing not only to conservation and regeneration of forests but also to livelihood generation and the vision of an Atmanirbhar Bharat. During the programme, he also interacted directly with the representatives and listened to their experiences, challenges, and suggestions. Describing Van Panchayats

as "the strongest link in India's democratic framework," Birla underlined that grassroots institutions play a vital role in conservation and governance. He remarked that interacting with Van Panchayats is akin to engaging with the most robust pillar of democracy and observed that the experience of these local bodies is no less significant than that of institutions at the national level.

RBI exempts small non-deposit taking NBFCs from registration requirement

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Mumbai

Non-deposit-taking NBFCs, with an asset size of less than ₹1,000 crore and not availing public funds, will be eligible for exemption from registration and reserve fund requirements from July 1, the Reserve Bank said on Wednesday. The central bank has issued a circular in this regard to reduce compliance requirements for such non-banking financial companies (NBFCs). "NBFCs not availing public funds and not having any customer interface, and having asset size of less than ₹1,000 crore as per the latest audited balance sheet are exempted from the provisions of sections 45IA and 45IC of the RBI Act, 1934...with effect from July 1, 2026," it said. Such existing NBFCs, including those holding Certificate of Registration as Type I NBFC, and fulfilling the prescribed criteria for exemption, can apply to the Reserve Bank for deregistration by December 31, 2026. While Section 45IA of the RBI Act is about the requirement of registration, Section 45IC states that NBFCs should create a reserve fund and transfer 20 per cent of their net profit

every year into it. These NBFCs are statutorily required to seek registration as NBFC under section 45IA of the RBI Act, 1934, to date. The Reserve Bank of India (Non-Banking Financial Companies - Registration, Exemptions and Framework for Scale Based Regulation) Amendment Directions, 2026, will come into effect from July 1, 2026. Earlier in February, the central bank had issued draft 'Reserve Bank of India (Non-Banking Financial Companies - Registration, Exemptions and Framework for Scale Based Regulation) Amendment Directions, 2026, seeking comments/feedback from the stakeholders. One of the suggestions on the draft was to remove the asset size limit and to exempt NBFCs with minuscule/peripheral instances of customer interface, which the RBI did not accept. "The asset size of ₹1,000 crore is viewed as a threshold level for systemic significance requiring oversight of the Reserve Bank," it said. Further, the intent is to provide exemption only to those NBFCs having a conscious and long-term business model of operating without public funds and customer interface, it added.



DAILY SUDOKU

2		6		8			
4	9	2				5	
		9					7
	3					4	6
8	6	4		7		3	9
7	4					2	
5				6			
	1			2		6	8
		5		9			1

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★☆☆☆☆

HOW TO SOLVE IT
Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction-no maths involved.



SOLUTION (29.04.26)								
8	4	7	3	6	9	5	1	2
1	3	9	5	2	8	7	4	6
6	5	2	7	4	1	3	8	9
4	2	5	6	8	3	9	7	1
3	7	6	9	1	4	8	2	5
9	1	8	2	7	5	6	3	4
7	8	1	4	5	6	2	9	3
2	6	3	1	9	7	4	5	8
5	9	4	8	3	2	1	6	7

DOUBLE CROSSWORD
THURSDAY | APRIL 30, 2026

1	2		3	4		5		6	7		8
			9								
10								11			
					12						
13		14							15		16
17							18				
						19					
20	21							22		23	
24							25				
						26					
27								28			
							29				
30									31		

- ACROSS**
- 1 It's exciting to have a drink with one (5)
6 Admitted having been bought? (5)
9 Seamen possibly love to forgive (7)
10 The place for fencing may be on the ski slopes (5)
11 Composer of "The Spanish Rag"? (5)
12 Pumping centre (5)
13 One whose parliamentary seat is free? (7)
15 Cry of a part-time worker (3)
17 She'll finish up out of iodine (4)
18 A piano on hire will suit (6)
19 Wrongly take to be a form of slate (5)
- DOWN**
- 2 It's sweet, but less than elevating (6)
3 Tangled with a couple of guys (6)
4 Holding a CD, he'd be perfectly in order (3)
5 No part of a travelogue is fiction (5)
6 The general, of course, is everybody's superior (7)
7 Part of a shoe left in the rain (4)
8 A steel product that stimulates! (6)
12 In which one eats rashly at a hotel? (5)
13 We get Les out of town (5)
14 After a bit, some duty becomes discontinuous (5)
- 20 A letter to declare one's property (6)
22 Eating his, could make a fathead sick (4)
24 Let's suppose aunt is robbed of £50 (3)
25 Cuts round the bend in certain channels (7)
26 Erotic, perhaps, but not without taste (5)
27 Something to hang on to? (5)
28 Vehicle to buy, horse included (5)
29 Student, initially one having a job (7)
30 Possibly dead at the end of the world, furthermore (5)
31 Would he attempt to embrace H.M.? (5)

- 15 It's wonderful how master Joe gets the car to start (5)
16 An author's deep sources? (5)
18 Friendly with a beginner in a new play (5)
19 Trod very softly taking a horse out (7)
21 A seasoned couple (6)
22 Fire about half the guns - a number, that is (6)
23 The book on the shelf to the right (6)
25 With a delicate cut? (5)
26 Bargain opportunity in town (4)
28 To live at central Tooting involves risk (3)

IIT Madras incubates over 100 startups, files 431 patents in innovation push

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Chennai



The IIT-Madras announced that it has achieved a milestone in deep-tech entrepreneurship, incubating over 100 startups for the second consecutive year under its 'Startup Shatam' mission. Through its nodal incubator, IITM Incubation Cell (IITMIC), the institute incubated 112 startups in FY 2025-26, building on last year's milestone. In parallel, IIT Madras sustained its innovation momentum, filing 431 patents during the year and reinforcing its leadership in translating research into real-world impact, a release from IIT-Madras said. Professor V Kamakoti, Director, IIT Madras, who had set the goal of '100 startups a year' in 2024 and 'one patent a day' in 2023, made the announcements to students, faculty, researchers and startup founders during world Intellectual Property (IP) day celebrations held on campus. He said the highlight of this year's 'Startup Shatam' milestone is the growing maturity and diversity of startups entering the ecosystem. Over 60 per cent of the startups were founded by external entrepreneurs across the country.

According to him, IIT Madras students, faculty and researchers also continued to drive innovation output, with 431 patents filed during financial year 2025-26, supported by the Institutes' IP ecosystem and commercialisation efforts led by its IP management cell. The newly incubated startups span a wide range of critical deep tech sectors, including manufacturing, robotics, automotive, batteries, defense, aerospace, AI, machine learning, quantum technologies, analytics, fintech, healthtech, agritech, biotech, climate technologies, Internet of Things — IoT, and cyber-physical systems. On the IP front, IIT Madras highlighted strong activity in frontier areas such as artificial intelligence and machine learning, quantum technologies, semiconductors, 5G/6G, robotics, advanced manufacturing, sustainable energy systems, photonics, blockchain, biomedical imaging, and advanced materials.

Army, State police conduct successful joint operations in upper Assam

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

In a series of intelligence-based joint operations conducted in the month of April 2026, the Indian Army's Red Shield Gunners, under the aegis of Spear Corps, in coordination with Assam Police, achieved significant success in Upper Assam districts of Tinsukia, Charaideo and Sivasagar. The operations, based on precise TECHINT and HUMINT inputs, led to the apprehension of one ULFA(I) cadre, ten Over Ground Workers (OGWs) and four drug dealers with established links to anti-national elements. Additionally narcotics were also recovered during the operations. These coordinated efforts highlight the effectiveness of joint operations in countering anti-national activities and disrupting support networks in the region.



Guru Nanak Dev University, Amritsar

Advertisement No. 02/2026

Walk-in-Interview

Walk in interview is proposed for the position of Coaches for various Sports Discipline in the Sports Department on contract basis on fixed salary. Details of walk-in-interview as available on www.digital.gndu.ac.in 29-04-2026 Registrar Amritsar

2426/12/2026-27/11010 Dated CHD :- 29/04/2026

Admission Notice for Law Courses in Punjab (2026-27)

As per the notification No. HED-EDU10N0TC/1/2020-3Edu/11/1357632/2026 Dated 01/04/2026 of Punjab Government, Guru Nanak Dev University, Amritsar is going to conduct Centralized Online Counselling for Admission to B.A. LL.B. (Hons.) Five Years/ B.A. LL.B. Five Years/ LL.B. Three Years/ B.Com. LL.B. Five Years/ B.Com. LL.B. (Hons) Five Years and B.B.A. LL.B. Five Years course for the session 2026-27 for the Sri Guru Teg Bahadur State University of Law, Tarn Taran and institutions/Colleges situated in Punjab and affiliated to Guru Nanak Dev University, Amritsar, Panjab University, Chandigarh and Punjabi University, Patiala. For eligibility, Online filling of forms, Fee and other details, the desirous candidates must see the website <http://punjablawadmissions.gndu.ac.in>. The participating institutions are requested to submit the mandatory proforma latest by 05.05.2026 through Dean, College Development Council of the concerned universities. For more details, updates and all the requisite instructions, check the admission website regularly.

2426/12/2026-27/11014 Dated CHD :- 29/04/2026

BRIEFLY

Afghan women’s refugee team to play in FIFA meet



An Afghanistan women’s refugee team has been granted eligibility for international competitions, some five years after national team players fled their country’s Taliban rule.

The FIFA Council, meeting in Vancouver, British Columbia, agreed on Tuesday to amend its regulations to recognize the refugee team, which plays under the name Afghan Women United. While it is too late for the refugee team to try to qualify for the 2027 Women’s World Cup in Brazil, it could participate in qualification for the 2028 Olympics in Los Angeles. “We are proud of the beautiful journey initiated by Afghan Women United, and with this initiative we aim to enable them, as well as other FIFA member associations that may not be able to register a national or representative team for a FIFA competition, to make the next step, in coordination with the relevant confederation,” FIFA President Gianni Infantino said in a statement.

FIFA enacts new World Cup rule on yellow cards



FIFA has tweaked World Cup rules on yellow cards to ensure fewer players are suspended for key elimination games. An extra amnesty for yellow cards - wiping player disciplinary records twice during the expanded tournament in North America - was proposed to a meeting Tuesday of FIFA’s ruling council. Later FIFA issued a statement confirming the change.

“Reflective of the expanded format with an extra knockout round, the FIFA Council confirmed an amendment to the regulations for the FIFA World Cup 2026 whereby single yellow cards in the final competition will be canceled after the group stage and then again after the quarterfinals,” it said.

At the World Cup, players must serve a one-game ban if they are shown a yellow card in two different games but single yellow cards were canceled at previous tournaments after the quarterfinals stage. That ensured no player would miss the final through suspension just because of getting a yellow card in the semifinal.

How electric changes to F1 will impact Miami GP

JAMES ELLINGWORTH ■ Miami

Formula 1 is back, and the show has changed. This week’s Miami Grand Prix is the first test of a package of changes that curb the influence of the electrical battery power which has redefined how F1 drivers go racing in 2026.

Drawn up during the enforced month-long break when races in the Middle East were called off, the changes follow a backlash from many drivers aggrieved at the regular need to go slow to charge the all-important battery. Max Verstappen is publicly considering whether to leave F1 entirely.

The electrical power has produced some thrilling on-track action with plenty of overtaking, but fans and drivers are split over how much driver skill matters when many moves are hard to defend against. Champion Lando Norris has even reported making overtakes by mistake when the power kicked in unexpectedly.

Many senior F1 figures are playing



down the changes or deny there was a problem in the first place. Toto Wolff, whose Mercedes team dominated the first three changes, wanted changes made with a scalpel, not a baseball bat. The rule makers seem to have listened.

Nikolas Tombazis, the top F1 regulations official at the FIA, the sport’s governing body, sees his role as a doctor prescribing diet, exercise or vitamins.

“It was quite clear we need to take certain steps. I think it was quite clear that people also need to come out of their comfort zone for some of these discussions,” he said Monday.

Avoiding another huge crash

Drivers had been warning for months about big differences in speed, and the big crashes that could result.

It finally happened at the Japanese

Goals galore as PSG beats Bayern Munich in record-setting CL semis



JEROME PUGMIRE ■ Paris

Titleholder Paris Saint-Germain trailed early, led by three goals and ultimately held on for a pulsating 5-4 win over Bayern Munich in the highest-scoring semifinal match in Champions League history.

And there’s still next week’s second leg to come.

PSG built a 5-2 lead early in the second half thanks to two goals each from flying winger Khvicha Kvaratskhelia and Ousmane Dembele at Parc des Princes.

“We deserved to win, we deserved to lose, we

deserved to draw,” PSG coach Luis Enrique said.

“It was an exceptional match, I have never experienced a match of such intensity as a coach. I have never seen a rhythm like that, it was incredible, you have to congratulate all the players.” Down by three goals, Bayern fought back brilliantly.

Defender Dayot Upamecano’s header midway through the second half from Joshua Kimmich’s free kick gave Bayern hope and Luis Diaz’s stinging strike made it a one-goal deficit heading into next Wednesday’s return leg in Munich.

“I think something special can happen at home, there will be 75,000 people, it will be a hell of an atmosphere,” Bayern coach Vincent Kompany said. “The Allianz Arena is a mythical area where Bayern has enjoyed much success.”

Rather than scale back and defend more, Kompany said he was ready to take even more risks.

“There is no middle ground,” he said. “We will give everything, everything, everything we have. We’re waiting for them, we want this.” Kompany was suspended and watched from the stands, so assistant

Aaron Danks took over on the touchline as Bayern lost for the first time in any competition since Jan. 24.

Harry Kane’s penalty gave Bayern the lead in the 17th minute and Kvaratskhelia equalized soon after for PSG. Midfielder Joao Neves—who is 5-foot-7—then headed PSG ahead from a corner.

A dramatic first half saw Michael Olise equalise for Bayern after bursting into the area before Swiss referee Sandro Scharer awarded a penalty for PSG when a video review spotted a handball from Canada defender Alphonso Davies. (AP)

Watching thriller from stands ‘no fun’ for suspended coach

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Paris

Vincent Kompany might have been the only spectator in the Parc des Princes who didn’t enjoy watching the thrilling Champions League semifinal game between his Bayern Munich team and Paris Saint-Germain.

Barred from the touchline as he served a one-game suspension, Kompany found it hard to be further from the action as he sat with staff in the media seats wearing an earpiece.

“It’s no fun,” Kompany told Prime Video.

“If it never happens again, I’ll be satisfied.”

The twists and turns of PSG’s 5-4 first-leg win were clear to see on Kompany’s face. With assistant Aaron Danks taking charge on the touchline, Kompany was sharing smiles and handshakes with staff in the first half, but was stone-faced as his team slumped to 5-2 down before charging back into the contest.

“I can’t take decisions 80 meters (262 feet) away,” Kompany said.

“But I appreciated the way the players responded, from high up in the stands.”

Kompany’s PSG counterpart Luis Enrique had a different view from the sideline, proclaiming it the best game he’s ever coached.



In the past, Luis Enrique has occasionally taken a seat in the stands of his own free will to get a tactical view of the game, but Kompany wasn’t convinced.

“I don’t know why. I wouldn’t do that,” the Belgian coach said.

With Kompany out of “the vicinity of the field of play or the team bench” as UEFA rules demand, and also barred from the locker room, Danks took charge of a game for the first time since a two-game interim stint at Aston Villa in 2022.

Danks is Bayern’s set-piece specialist but his team still managed to concede a simple headed goal from a corner when Joao Neves evaded his marker Jamal Musiala to put PSG 2-1 up.

Korda is back in her bubble and a big year could await

DOUG FERGUSON ■ Houston

Rory McIlroy spent 17 years trying to win the Masters, and when he faced the media for the first time wearing his green jacket, he asked, “What are we going to talk about next year?”

It wasn’t that bad for Nelly Korda, even if it felt that way. The questions about a lifetime goal she was chasing didn’t come every year at one tournament. They were crammed into a single season, asking whether she could live up to the past.

Korda won seven times in 2024, the most on the LPGA Tour in 17 years. And then last year she didn’t win at all, even though her statistics

were similar, if not better in some areas.

“A super frustrating year,” she said. “I would come into a room like this and everyone would be like, Your stats are great, better than last year, but you have zero trophies under your name this year.’ I’m like, I see that, yes.’ It wears on you because that’s what you’re working for.”

Frustration led to too much thinking, too much analysing. She wasn’t trying to reinvent the wheel, but her wheels were spinning without going anywhere.

“That was paralyzing me,” she said. “I told myself I don’t ever want to feel like that on a golf course.”

Korda looked nothing like that over four days at Memorial Park when she won The Chevron Championship with a dominance not seen at an LPGA major in 35 years. (AP)

Red cards can be given to players who cover their mouths while confronting opponents

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Vancouver

The International Football Association Board approved a new rule Tuesday that would penalise players with a red card if they cover their mouths when verbally confronting another player.

The rule was unanimously approved by IFAB at a meeting held Tuesday in Vancouver, British Columbia. The measure will be in place at this summer’s World Cup, starting on June 11.

FIFA proposed the rule after Real Madrid’s Vinicius Junior accused Benfica’s Gianluca Prestianni of making a racially charged insult while covering his mouth during a Champions League match in February.

Last week, UEFA handed Prestianni a six-game ban for the verbal abuse, which it



said were homophobic in nature.

If Prestianni is selected for Argentina’s World Cup squad, he could have to sit out the defending champion’s first two matches this summer, although the ban can be appealed.

“At the discretion of the competition organiser, any player covering their mouth in a confrontational situation with an opponent may be sanctioned with a red card,” IFAB announced.

The organization, which sets the rules for international soccer, also announced that any player who leaves the field in protest of a referee’s decision can be sanctioned with a red card. The rule also applies to team officials who urge players to leave the field.

IFAB said the amendments will be communicated to all 48 teams playing in the World Cup, hosted by the United States, Canada and Mexico.

Iran skips meeting of Asia soccer leaders

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Vancouver

Representatives from Iran’s soccer federation were not present at the largest formal meeting of Asia’s soccer leaders before this summer’s World Cup.

In the presence of FIFA President Gianni Infantino, there was no discussion at the Asian Football Confederation Congress about Iran’s participation in the tournament or whether the team’s games should be moved out of the United States because of the conflict between the two nations.

There have been concerns that visa issues could impact the Iranian delegation’s ability to travel to both Tuesday’s confederation meeting in Vancouver, British Columbia, and the overall FIFA Congress on Thursday, as well as the



World Cup starting on June 11. The 48-team tournament is being hosted by the United States, Canada and Mexico.

It was not clear if visa issues prevented Iranian representatives from attending the AFC Congress. However, as the nine AFC teams that qualified for the World Cup were presented with commemorative gifts, it was announced that Iran would receive its token “once they arrive.”

An Iranian government spokesperson said last week

that the national team was preparing for “proud and successful participation” in its World Cup games in the United States.

FIFA, soccer’s international governing body, has consistently said Iran will stick to the World Cup game schedule decided last December, before the US and Israel launched military attacks on Feb. 28, and has refused to entertain suggestions that the team’s games be moved to Mexico.

Why workouts of Formula 1 drivers might help computer users with ‘tech neck’

JAMES ELLINGWORTH ■ Washington

Keeping your eyes on the road is vital if your car travels at a speed of 200 mph (322 kph). A strong neck helps.

Neck-strengthening exercises are integral in the fast-paced world of Formula 1 racing. Plenty of drivers will bring specialized training gear for that purpose when they arrive in Florida for Sunday’s Miami Grand Prix, the next event of a lucrative, year-long championship which spans the globe.

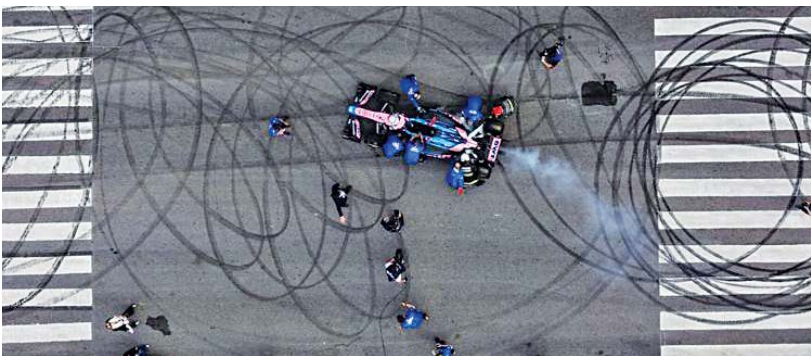
Working out with weighted harnesses or using deep body-weight stretches stabilize their heads and help them stay focused on the track through high-speed corners while forces up to five times as strong as gravity heave their bodies from side to side.

Adults with “tech neck” don’t work in

such extreme conditions, but the training techniques of professional race car drivers highlight an often-overlooked muscle group. Paying greater attention to posture while using screens and adding neck-specific exercises to a fitness routine are small changes that could ease discomfort, according to Dr. Neeru Jayanthi, an Atlanta-based sports medicine specialist who works with athletes of all ages from a range of sports.

“Does a normal person need to have a neck like an F1 driver? Probably not,” Antti Kontsas, an experienced performance coach who worked with four-time F1 champion Sebastian Vettel and other stars of the sport, said.

Still, “the healthy foundations are the same for the normal person and for the driver. Where you would start is exactly the same,” Kontsas told The Associated Press.



As with any other fitness activity, neck training needs to be practiced safely and with attention to an individual’s physical needs and limitations. When in doubt, seek guidance from a doctor or other medical professional, especially if

you have experienced neck injuries or don’t know what might be causing your aching neck.

When you’re aware of your limits, “it’s just knowing the loading, exposing gradually. That’s the safe way to

progress,” Kontsas says.

How drivers train

The days when F1 drivers smoke and drank before a Grand Prix are long gone. Even in the 1990s, fitness was crucial to Michael Schumacher’s success; the seven-time champion from Germany emphasized cardio and strength training. After all, fatigue causes mistakes.

A key element of Kontsas’ training programs is not overlooking the neck, otherwise known as the cervical spine, when exercising your back and core.

Body-weight exercises like keeping the head level with the shoulders in a lateral, or side, plank position can help. Another easy exercise can be done lying down.

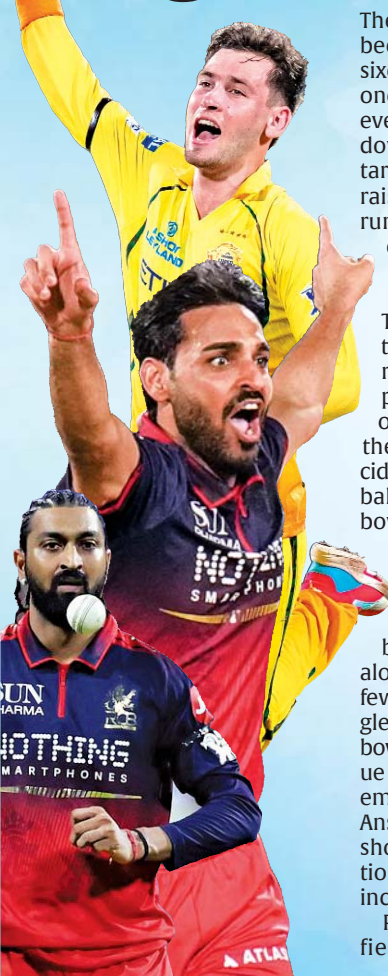
“The most simple thing is lying on your back on a bench with your head hanging and then holding your head in

a complete horizontal line. You’re holding your head still and seeing how long you can hold that. That’s a good way to train, particularly, the front musculature,” Kontsas said.

To increase the challenge, drivers typically use a resistance band or a weighted harness that straps around the head to work their neck muscles.

Beating the pain of computer neck? Training doesn’t have to take up a lot of time. Even F1 drivers might only do neck exercises for 10 to 15 minutes a session, two or three times a week, according to Kontsas. If you spend a lot of time at a desk for work, improving neck health can start with a simple reminder to be aware of your posture and simple stretches like tucking the chin back to compensate for leaning forward toward a screen. (AP)

High scores in the IPL: Great Marketing or Bad Sport



The modern Indian Premier League has become synonymous with towering sixes and record-breaking chases. Totals once considered match-winning, 200, even 210-220, are now routinely chased down with overs to spare. When a target as steep as 265 can be chased, it raises a legitimate question: are these run-fests a natural evolution of T20 cricket, or a symptom of a format tipping out of balance?

There is no denying that batting in T20 cricket has undergone a revolution. A new generation of players has redefined risk. These are batters who play with a license to attack from ball one, unburdened by the fear of losing their wicket. In India's case, this coincides with a golden generation of white-ball batters capable of dismantling any bowling attack on their day. The result is an aggressive brand of cricket where even a required rate of 12 per over feels manageable.

Yet, this transformation cannot be attributed to batting evolution alone. The quality of bowling, barring a few notable exceptions, has often struggled to keep pace. While experienced bowlers like Bhuvneshwar Kumar continue to demonstrate control and skill, and emerging names such as Prince Yadav, Anshul Kamboj, and Eshan Malinga have shown promise, they remain exceptions this current season in a format increasingly skewed toward batters.

Pitch conditions have further amplified this imbalance. Many venues



SHAKYA MITRA

produce flat tracks with minimal assistance for seam or spin, effectively turning contests into batting exhibitions. While such surfaces ensure high-scoring thrillers, they often leave bowlers with little margin for error. A slightly missed length or line is punished severely, reducing the contest to execution under extreme pressure rather than a genuine battle between bat and ball.

Another critical factor shaping this trend is the introduction of the Impact Player rule. On paper, it offers strategic flexibility to both teams. In practice, however, it has significantly strengthened batting line-ups. Teams now bat as deep as eight or nine, allowing top- and middle-order players to attack relentlessly without worrying about collapses. The knowledge that there is ample batting depth behind them has fundamentally altered risk calculation.

While the rule theoretically allows bowling sides to play an extra specialist bowler than a T1 versus T1 contest, the timing often undermines its effectiveness. Often the damage that has been done in the first 8-10 overs by the batting side nullifies the impact that playing an extra specialist bowler would bring.

Team composition strategies have

also played a role. Several franchises have invested heavily in star batters and batting all-rounders, operating on the philosophy that overwhelming opposition with runs is a safer route than relying on bowlers to defend totals. However, history suggests that the most successful teams in the IPL are those that strike a balance. Championships are rarely won by batting alone; quality bowling units capable of controlling games under pressure remain indispensable.

This imbalance is also reflected in the auction dynamics. Elite batters often command astronomical prices, while only a handful of bowlers attract similar attention. The scarcity of high-quality T20 bowlers, combined with the format's inherent bias toward batting, has created a market where bowlers are undervalued relative to their impact.

One proposed solution is the introduction of bigger boundaries. Larger playing areas would naturally curb the frequency of sixes and reward better shot placement over brute power. However, this is easier said than done, as stadium dimensions are often fixed and constrained by infrastructure.

Despite these concerns, it is



important to acknowledge the entertainment factor. Run-fests are undeniably appealing to spectators and television audiences. High scores, dramatic chases, and last-over finishes drive viewership and engagement, which are central to the league's commercial success. In a product-driven ecosystem like the IPL, entertainment value cannot be dismissed lightly.

The real question, then, is whether the league can maintain this excitement without compromising the integrity of the sport. Cricket, at its core, thrives on balance, the tension between bat and ball. When one side consistently dominates, the contest risks becoming predictable, even if the scores remain high.

Ultimately, the IPL's run-fests are a combination of evolution and excess. They reflect the natural progression of batting innovation, but also expose structural imbalances in pitch preparation, team composition, and rule design. Rather than viewing them purely as great marketing or dismissing them as bad sport, it is more accurate to see them as a phase in the format's ongoing evolution.

(Shakya Mitra is a sports management consultant with over a decade of experience in sports promotion and development. His work across both the private and government sectors gives him a well-rounded view of India's sports ecosystem)

Sunrisers Hyderabad beat Mumbai Indians by 6 wickets

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

Mumbai

Ryan Rickelton's whirlwind unbeaten ton was overshadowed by Heinrich Klaasen's unbeaten 65 as Sunrisers Hyderabad defeated Mumbai Indians by six wickets in an IPL match here on Wednesday.

Chasing an imposing 244-run target, Travis Head (76 off 30) and Abhishek Sharma (45 off 24) shared 129 runs for the opening wicket to set the platform for SRH.

Klaasen (65 not out off 30 balls) then displayed his all-round hitting abilities to guide SRH home with the help of Nitish Kumar Reddy (21) and Salil Arora (30 not out off 10) in 18.4 overs.

Earlier, Rickelton's knock powered MI to 243 for five.

MI rode on a 93-run stand between Rickelton (123 not out off 55 balls) and Will Jacks (46 off 22) in 7.1 overs for the opening stand to power the side.

MI skipper Hardik Pandya scored a valuable 31 off 15 balls before being dismissed.



In the previous innings, Ryan Rickelton struck the fastest ever century by a Mumbai Indians batter to propel his team to massive 243 for five in their must-win IPL clash

against Sunrisers Hyderabad, here on Wednesday.

Rickelton batted through the innings for an unbeaten 123 off a mere 55 balls with 10 fours and

eight sixes, anchoring MI's charge to an at-par total on a batting friendly track here at the Wankhede Stadium.

The 29-year-old Rickelton

brought up a third century for his franchise as MI made a desperate attempt to revive their fortunes with their highest total of the season so far.

Using the long handle to maximum effect, not for once did Rickelton take any unwarranted risk but executed his strokes with conviction.

Alongside Rickelton's exploits, MI also had England opener Will Jacks (46 off 22 balls) and skipper Hardik Pandya (31 off 15 balls; 2 fours, 2 sixes) delivering the goods.

With a new opening partner in the form of Jacks, the South African wicketkeeper-batter Rickelton provided MI with the spunk they have missed most of this season hitherto.

The pair put on 78 in the power-play and 93 for the first wicket in seven overs to set the tone in a fearless approach with the bat.

But more importantly, Rickelton hung around for a long haul as his innings proved to be the glue which held MI together as well as kept driving them towards a strong total.

GT face rampant RCB at home



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

Ahmedabad

Searching for some much needed consistency, Gujarat Titans face a stern test against a red-hot Royal Challengers Bengaluru in their Indian Premier League match here on Thursday.

At the halfway stage of the tournament, Gujarat Titans find themselves stuck in mid-table with four wins and as many losses from eight games.

In contrast, defending champions RCB have been in imperious form, registering six victories in eight matches.

RCB's new ball duo of Bhuvneshwar Kumar and Josh Hazlewood has wreaked havoc in tandem. While Bhuvneshwar has turned back the clock with his swing masterclass, Hazlewood has troubled the batters with

Test match lengths targeting the outside edge.

Add to that, the challenge of facing Krunal Pandya and his barrage of variations in the middle overs.

GT have been labelled as top heavy with Sai Sudharsan, captain Shubman Gill and Jos Buttler again scoring the bulk of the runs. Washington Sundar has proved himself in the middle order while finishers like Shikhar Dhawan and Rahul Tewatia have not set the stage on fire yet.

Jason Holder has been accommodated in the middle-order to lend more potency.

Both sides met only a week ago at the Chinnaswamy with RCB comfortably chasing down 206 with seven balls to spare. GT have also not been able to dominate at home, having lost two of their three games at Motera.

Riyan Parag caught vaping on camera

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

New Delhi

Rajasthan Royals captain Riyan Parag has courted controversy after TV cameras caught him "vaping" in the dressing room during his team's Indian Premier League game against Punjab Kings in Mullanpur.

The Indian government had banned e-cigarettes back in 2019, prohibiting their production, sale and distribution. As per the law, the offender faces imprisonment up to one year and/or a ₹ one lakh fine for a first time offence.

Parag, who has not had the best of times with the bat this IPL, was seen inhaling an e-cigarette, also known as



vaping, in the dressing room during the live broadcast of their game against Punjab Kings on Tuesday night.

The act caught on camera triggered immediate reaction on social media. Parag made a 16-ball 29 in his team's successful chase of 223.

IPL and BCCI officials involved in the conduct of

the IPL termed it as a careless act in the age of social media and prying TV cameras.

"A lot of players consume e-cigarettes but they don't do it in the dressing room. It is too risky and careless to be doing that with so many cameras around. With Parag caught vaping so openly, the BCCI might be forced to act," said a well placed IPL source.

Kothari defeats Advani to retain world billiards title

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

Carlow (Ireland)

Sourav Kothari outclassed compatriot Pankaj Advani in 75a lop-sided final to retain the IBSF World Billiards Championship title here.

The Kolkata defeated the 19-time champion Advani 1133-477 in a lop-sided three-hour final.

After the initial blues, the 41-year-old came up with a barrage of breaks to floor Advani. He had stupendous runs of 485, 121, 90, 241 and an unfinished 155.

"I wanted to do it again for my father. This one was for you, Dad," he said after the final in memory of his father Manoj Kothari, who had passed away early this year.



"Obviously, it feels incredible to win the World title, and to defend it is even more special," said Kothari. The sizzling 485 in reply to his rival's 141 early in the match set the tone.

If the 485, which culminated with a missed red pot

to the centre pocket, wasn't a hammer blow, the 121 and 90 breaks in quick succession, took the match away from Advani.

Trailing 224-700 with a little over an hour until the bell, the Bengalurean made a 64 before rushing an in-off to the top left-hand pocket. Kothari punished that error with another silken-smooth 241 effort to take a whopping 941-288 lead.

Under pressure, Advani compiled a break of 119 — which ended when he missed a thin in-off to the centre pocket — to reduce the deficit.

Kothari was not done yet as he came up with a flowing 155 before the bell went off.

Veteran Indian golfer Vijay Kumar dies



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

New Delhi

Veteran Indian golfer Vijay Kumar has died in his home town Lucknow due to a heart attack. He was 57.

The winner of the 2002 Indian Open and a four-time Order of Merit champion, Vijay was among the most accomplished and respected names in Indian professional golf.

Ayush, Prannoy win but India lose 2-3 to China in Thomas Cup Finals

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

Horsens (Denmark)

India went down 2-3 to China in their final Group A tie of the Thomas Cup Finals, despite fighting comeback wins from Ayush Shetty and HS Prannoy here on Wednesday.

The 2022 champions India, who have already sealed their quarterfinal spot, were on the back foot after Lakshya Sen and the doubles pair of Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty lost close encounters to concede a 0-2 lead. Under pressure, Ayush delivered, recovering from a game down to beat Weng Hong Yang 17-21, 21-13, 21-15 in the second singles and reduce the margin.



It came down to the second doubles match but the pair of Hariharan Amsakarunan and MR Arjun couldn't get across He Ji Ting and Ren Xiang Yu, losing 17-21 13-21 as China took an unassailable 3-1 lead.

Prannoy then rallied from a game down to beat Lu Guang Zu 20-22, 21-19, 21-11 in the third singles to



reduce the margin of the defeat.

Lakshya, a 2021 world championships bronze medallist, had beaten world No. 7 Li Shi Feng en route to a runner-up finish at the All England Championships last month but he could not replicate that form in the decider, going down 19-21 21-8 12-21 in the first singles.

Sri Lanka Government to take over SLC administration



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

Colombo

Sri Lanka government on Wednesday decided to take over the administration of the country's cricket board after the resignation of its president Shammi Silva and the executive committee.

Sri Lanka Cricket chief Silva and other office bearers stepped down on Tuesday after Lankan president Anura Kumara Dissanayake negotiated a peaceful exit for them after

mounting allegations of financial irregularities.

"Accordingly under the powers vested in him by sections 31 and 34 of the sports law No 25 of 1973, all administrative functions of Sri Lanka Cricket will be temporarily brought under the ministry of youth affairs and sports," stated a release from Sports Minister Sunil Kumara Gamage.

Gamage said the resignations of the existing set of office-bearers have been accepted.

Trust, communication with players is key for success as coach: Sarfaraz

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

Karachi

Mutual trust and clear communication with players is key for becoming a successful coach, Pakistan's new Test format head coach Sarfaraz Ahmed said on Wednesday.

The first assignment for the 2017 Champions Trophy winning captain will be a two-Test series in Bangladesh from May 8 which will be Pakistan's second outing in the ongoing ICC World Test Championship cycle.

"The technical aspects come later. What is important is a coach has such a relationship with his players that they understand what he wants and at the same time they are comfortable and trust him enough to sit down with him and discuss anything," Sarfaraz said while responding to a question about his limited experience as coach.

Majority of the players named in the Test squad for Bangladesh are busy playing in the Pakistan Super League final stages and the wicket-keeper-batter admitted it would be a challenge for even senior players to adapt to red-ball cricket after playing



T20 cricket for over a month now.

Sarfaraz also felt that having played with some of the players in the Test squad and having captained them it would be a plus point to settle into his new job.

The former captain was last year named mentor and manager of the Pakistan under-19 and Shaheens (Pakistan A) squad.

He accompanied them for the Asia Cup and World Youth Cup but on returning home he was appointed a member of the national selection committee and later the red ball head coach.

"I had a very good cricket career and I want to repeat the success as a coach. I have gained some experience in coaching at the domestic level and at the cricket academy but obviously Test cricket is very different and I am confident with time the exposure will help me a lot," he added.